Pay It Forward

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/46510444.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Angst, Implied/Referenced Child Abuse, Transphobia, transphobic language, Angst with a Happy Ending, I can't write a short fic anymore it seems

Language:
English

Series:
Part 10 of Camp Bright Moon

Stats:
Published: 2023-04-15 Completed: 2023-04-24 Words: 25,262 Chapters: 5/5

Pay It Forward

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/46510444.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Angst, Implied/Referenced Child Abuse, Transphobia, transphobic language, Angst with a Happy Ending, I can't write a short fic anymore it seems

Language:
English

Series:
Part 10 of Camp Bright Moon

Stats:
Published: 2023-04-15 Completed: 2023-04-24 Words: 25,262
Chapters: 5/5

Pay It Forward

by TheSofterGentlerMe

Summary

Catra and Adora struck out on their own so they could live their lives at the age of 18. However, no one does anything completely by themselves and they had plenty of help. Now, with a knock on the door one night, they have a chance to pay that help forward.

Chapter One

Chapter Summary

It all starts with a knock.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora was dreaming of her upcoming dissertation, tossing a little in her sleep, when she heard the knock. She woke up, staring at the wall, and didn't hear Catra as much as sense her sitting silently on the edge of the bed. Adora saw her shift a little in the dim light of the bedroom, her voice almost inaudible over the two fans running in the room.

"Someone's here."

"I heard," Adora said back as she pulled on a sweatshirt in the chilly air of the room and slipped her feet into some slippers.

"What are you doing?" Catra said.

"I'm answering the door," Adora said as she opened the door to the bedroom.

"No, you are not. It is two in the morning," Catra hissed as Adora walked towards the front door. The living room was a bit better lit from light coming in from the street outside to their second floor apartment. Adora ignored the fact that Catra had one of her blacksmith hammers in her hand.

"Which means someone really needs us," Adora said as she stopped at the door and looked through the peephole. Her brow furrowed a little to see two people standing there. One she knew, a person named Kaitlyn who'd started at the college Adora was

attending for her masters at the start of the semester a few months before. Adora had been her camp counselor years before at a church camp, a position she'd left in metaphorical flames by announcing she was a lesbian at the top of her voice in front of most of the camp and walking off with Catra. She'd recently reunited with Kaitlyn after a chance run in at the beginning of the semester

Now Adora wondered what was going on because Kaitlyn looked furious while the person standing next to her looked miserable, eyes red and face looking down. Adora couldn't help but notice that Kaitlyn was holding a duffel bag.

"It's Kaitlyn and someone else," Adora said.

"Well don't leave them standing out there," Catra said, gesturing with the hammer at the door. Adora rolled her eyes, avoiding pointing out that Catra hadn't even wanted to answer the door a few moments before. As soon as Adora had the door open, Kaitlyn started talking.

"I'm really sorry to be here this late but you were the first person I thought of and I figured you'd be able to help and I'm sorry for waking you up…"

Adora held up a hand as she blinked and adjusted to the light coming in from the hallway.

"OK, I get it, come inside," Adora said as she stepped sideways and the room behind her got a little brighter as Catra turned on a little lamp. Catra couldn't help but notice that the other person seemed to relax just a small bit as the two got inside. Not much though, both of them were still bundles of nerves. Catra set the hammer down on their coffee table as she spoke up.

"Neither of you would be here this late if something wasn't wrong so let's just skip the whole apology and one of you just say why you're here."

Kaitlyn looked at the other person for a moment who looked back at her with pleading eyes. Kaitlyn put her arm around them and hugged them tight as she said, “This is Madison. She’s… sorry, I mean they’re having trouble. Their parents kicked them out tonight and I thought of you, um, because you know.”

Adora looked at Madison and for a moment she could almost feel the dock under her feet at Camp Bright Moon as she made a decision and altered the course of her entire life. She wondered if this night was going to be the same kind of memory for Madison in the future as she spoke up before Kaitlyn could go on.

“I’m guessing you got kicked out because you’re not straight,” Adora said.

Madison didn’t respond at first and Kaitlyn gave them an encouraging squeeze.

“Yeah,” they finally said, their voice quiet and shaking.

Catra was sitting on the edge of the coffee table, leaned forward onto her legs, as she looked at Adora who looked right back at her. Catra gave a little shrug and Adora nodded.

“OK, sit down,” Adora said as she looked back at the two.

Madison hesitated for a moment and then sat down on the edge of an old couch, the couch sinking a little as they did. Kaitlyn sat down next to them, putting the duffel bag on the ground as her arm went around them again. Madison fiddled with the buttons on their old coat as they looked at the floor.

Adora was about to speak up when Catra said, “Madison, when was the last time you ate something?”

Madison looked up at Catra in confusion as they said, “Uh, I guess lunch yesterday.”

Catra went into the kitchen as she said, “Allergies?”

Madison shook their head as Catra said, "I'll see what we got."

Madison was about to speak up when Adora, remembering Angella asking the same question years before, said, "Alright, I gotta ask this. Are you eighteen?"

Madison shook their head and Adora knew this was suddenly way more complicated. She settled on the edge of the coffee table that Catra had just left as Kaitlyn spoke up.

"It doesn't matter. Their parents threw them out. Right?"

Adora didn't know for sure but she knew she was probably up for the night.

"Catra, coffee if you can please," Adora said. Catra agreed as Adora looked at the two sitting on the couch in front of her. "And yeah, it could matter. First, tell me what's going on and what you're expecting here."

The story took a bit to get out. Kaitlyn and Madison talked over each other, trying to tell the story from their point of view and the both of them cried at various points. Catra quietly came in after a few minutes and set down a small serving tray with a few bowls of veggies, cold cuts, and cheese. Madison picked at the veggies and cheese for a few minutes in silence before going on.

It wasn't long before the story fit together. Madison lived with strict, religious parents. They'd been homeschooled and had just finished. They'd wanted to go to college but their parents hadn't been too eager, talking about marriage and family instead. This had been a back and forth thing for a while and the tension had slowly been rising from that. Catra caught a brief glimpse of a fresh bruise on Madison's wrist as they reached out to pick up a carrot stick and her mouth went into a thin line as she picked the hammer back up and fiddled with it as she listened.

To add to that, Madison had finally recognized that something was different about themself and they'd heard some talk from their parents that led them to think they might be transgender. They'd

snuck around on the family computer and at the library when they went and learned a bit about it and had come to the realization that they thought they might be nonbinary. Adora spoke up then.

"You told them?"

"Not at first," Madison said, shaking their head. "I knew what they'd do. They found a scrap of paper I'd written a call number on from the library and looked it up. They asked me about it and just wouldn't let up and finally I told them."

They started crying again and Kaitlyn pulled them in close as their head rested on her shoulder. Catra set the hammer back down and stood up.

"Take a moment," she said and then looked at Adora and shrugged her head at the bedroom. Adora nodded and followed Catra.

"I think it's obvious they want our help," Catra said quietly once they were both in the bedroom. "Probably a place to crash."

"Yeah, I think so," Adora said.

"What are we going to do?" Catra said.

"I'm not turning them away," Adora said, her voice suddenly stubborn. "Too many people helped us for us to turn our backs on someone."

Catra put a hand on Adora's shoulder as she said, "I feel the same way but they're seventeen and we need to understand that is a problem."

"I don't care," Adora said, crossing her arms.

Catra grunted with a little grin as she said, "Same but we need to act like we do. We're in agreement though? We're helping?"

"We're helping," Adora said.

“OK, go out there and get the rest of the story,” Catra said. “I’m calling Glimmer.”

“What? Why?” Adora said.

“She’s a lawyer, remember?” Catra said.

“She just passed the bar,” Adora said. “She hasn’t even argued a case yet.”

“Doesn’t matter. I figure this is a lawyer up kind of situation and she’s still a lawyer and really the only one we know. Or can afford for that matter,” Catra said as she went over to her nightstand and unplugged her phone from the charging cable and flipped it open.

“I’m going back out,” Adora said and Catra gave Adora thumbs up as she called Glimmer.

When Adora returned to the living room, Madison had a scared look and Kaitlyn was back to angry.

“OK, I think maybe I don’t need to know the rest of the story right now,” Adora said as she sat back down on the edge of the table. “Catra is calling a friend for some advice. What is it you need from us?”

Madison sat in silence and Kaitlyn finally spoke up.

Kaitlyn said, “I went and picked them up with my friend’s car but they can’t stay in my dorm. There’s no room and they’re strict about guests anyway.”

Adora was thinking about the story she’d heard already and she was beginning to think that Kaitlyn probably barely knew Madison. Even so, she’d still gone out in the middle of the night to get them. She also noticed that neither had still said what they needed, although Kaitlyn had alluded to it.

“Well, based on that, I’m guessing you need a place to stay,” Adora said. “You have one but I can’t promise for how long

because you're underage. The friend Catra is calling is a lawyer. We have to figure that out but I promise you we'll do everything we can."

"I don't want to be a trouble, ma'am," Madison said and Adora wanted to hug them tight at the fear and anxiety she saw glowing through them.

"I don't know what Kaitlyn told you about us but Catra and I were both in a similar place and people helped us. I can never, ever begin to give back what they did for us but I can do my best to give some measure of it to you," Adora said, ignoring the ma'am. "You are not a trouble."

Madison started to speak and got a little choked up but they finally said, "Thank you."

Adora leaned forward and hugged them tight as she said, "You're welcome."

Catra came out a few minutes later as Madison wiped at their eyes and said, "Glimmer's on her way."

"She lives almost an hour away," Adora said. "She could have just advised us over the phone."

"The way she drives it's like ten minutes down the road," Catra said with a snort. "And I said that but I could hear her throwing clothes on while Bow muttered in the background trying to figure out what was going on. I think she's excited to get her lawyer on." Catra looked down at the ground, suddenly uncomfortable, as she went on. "Madison, I, um, saw a bruise on your wrist earlier. You don't have to tell me anything but Glimmer said if that was from tonight, we should get pictures of it and any others if you agree to it."

Madison was shaking their head as they said, "I don't want to get them in trouble. I just want to not go back."

Catra stood looking at Madison for a moment before she said, "Madison, I understand how you feel. Let me show you how I understand." Catra rolled up her left sleeve and showed a few faded round scars on the underside of her arm. "My birth mother, reason I went into foster care as a kid and stayed there."

Adora looked in surprise at Catra. She'd never heard Catra tell anyone that so suddenly. She hadn't even found out what they were until they'd been dating for months. The only other people out of all their friends that knew were Glimmer and Bow.

"I'm not going to make you do anything. You tell me no, we're done with it. I'll let Glimmer know to drop it when she gets here," Catra said. "Just know that you won't have to go back to them if you don't want to."

Adora was about to speak up and give stipulations on it, about how it was based on the legal situation, but Catra looked at Adora and Adora could see in the last few minutes something had shifted in Catra and she didn't care about stipulations anymore. She'd seen Catra angry before but nothing like this. It was something deep that only showed in her eyes and Adora was a bit in awe at it. She was also very glad it wasn't directed at her.

"You're not going back," Catra said, looking at Adora.

"Hey, you can trust them," Kaitlyn said gently to Madison. "Remember the stories that got whispered around at camp? I was there. I saw it. They were unbelievable."

"There's stories about us?" Adora said.

"Uh, yeah, I guess I didn't tell you about those," Kaitlyn said, looking a little awkward.

"Well you're going to have to know. Well, later but yeah, I gotta know," Catra said and then they all turned to look at Madison who was shaking but was pulling back their sleeve to show a bruise. The shape was odd, white skin in between a few lines of bruises

when Adora suddenly realized that it had been made by fingers grasping Madison's wrist and felt sick to her stomach.

Catra knelt down and said, "Thank you for trusting us."

Adora got her phone, which had a camera where Catra's didn't, and handed it to Catra who began to take pictures. There weren't tons of bruises but there were enough, each shape telling a nasty story, and Adora had to turn away as tears streamed down her face. Catra kept it together though and gave quiet, reassuring words to Madison as she took several photos of each from different angles. Once that was done, Catra gave Madison a blanket from the back of the couch and put their coat on a kitchen chair.

"You did well," Catra said gently. "Thank you again."

Everyone was quiet, no one quite sure what to say, and time stretched out. Adora looked at the clock and figured it wouldn't be long before Glimmer came. Adora knew she'd be exhausted in the morning but at the moment, she just felt wired. Madison, however, had leaned back against the couch and was nodding off and Kaitlyn was doing the same. Catra was looking off into the distance, not saying anything, as Adora put her arm around her.

"You did good as well," Adora said softly. Catra just looked at her with a tired smile, her eyes glistening a little from held back tears. They stayed that way for a few minutes, the soft hum of the heater starting changing a bit as the burners kicked on the only real background noise. Looking at Madison, mouth starting to hang open as they fell into sleep, Adora knew they were making the right choice.

Then there was a heavy pounding at the door.

Everyone sat bolt upright and stared at the door for a moment. Adora looked at Catra as she said, "There's no way that's Glimmer. She'd just come in."

“I know. Who the hell do you think knocks on a door like that in the middle of the night?” Catra said.

“Who?” Kaitlyn said, confused as Adora got up and walked to the door.

“The police,” Catra said as she stood up. “What are you doing?”

“Remember what Glimmer told us over and over when she was taking those constitutional law courses?” Adora said, her hands shaking. Catra nodded and Adora pointed at Madison and Kaitlyn. “Tell them.”

Catra turned to see Madison on the verge of panic and quickly began to tell them to stay quiet as Adora looked out the peephole. She saw two officers standing there, their heads looking a bit small against the bulked up chests from their body armor. One reached up to knock again and Adora spoke up before he could, her voice loud enough to carry through the door.

“What do you want?”

“Police. Please come out here, ma’am,” one of the officers said.

“No,” Adora said, swallowing hard.

“Then open the door so we can talk,” the officer said.

“Do you have a warrant?” Adora said and felt her legs shaking as adrenaline flooded through her.

“Ma’am, it’s hard to hear you through this door,” the other officer said. “Open the door and we can talk about this easier.”

Adora looked back to see Kaitlyn holding Madison tight and Catra was standing, her foot tapping quickly as she held Adora’s phone up, pointed at the door. Adora turned back and made her voice louder.

“Do you have a warrant?” she said, speaking slowly and clearly.

"Ma'am, there's no need to shout," the first officer said. "Just open the door. We just want to talk with you about something. We can get the landlord to let us in or you can save us the trouble."

Adora didn't know what to say to that. She wasn't sure if they could do that and hadn't counted on it but she swallowed, a remarkably difficult thing at the moment, and said, "If you don't have a warrant, I'm not letting you in and I'm done speaking with you."

She stayed at the peephole and watched the two officers. One stepped back and spoke into a radio and Adora almost opened the door then but just pushed her hands harder against the door instead. The other officer got closer and said, "Ma'am, if you don't open this door right this moment and speak to us, there could be a lot of trouble for you. You really should do it."

Adora felt like weeping but she just gritted her teeth to keep her mouth shut. She found herself reciting a Bible verse to herself over and over in her head as she stood there.

Yea, though I walk through the valley of the shadow of death, I shall fear no evil.

The verse didn't help much because she was very much afraid as the officer spoke again.

"Ma'am, this is ridiculous. Do you really want your neighbors to see this? Come on, open the door."

Adora closed her eyes.

"If we have to kick that door down, we will. I don't want to but we will if we have to."

I shall fear no evil, I shall fear no evil, I shall fear no evil, I shall fear no evil…

"My partner is talking to someone. Who knows, maybe they're getting that warrant. You really want to go through that trouble?

Just open the door."

Adora felt her stomach clamped down tight and thought she was going to throw up.

"He's coming back. I guess we might have to do this the hard way. That's on you if we do."

Adora's heart was thudding in her chest and she wondered if it was possible to have a heart attack from fear in your mid-20's. A little voice in her head was telling her to just open the door and explain because they were the police, the friendly people she remembered coming to her school to give little talks about Stranger Danger and Saying No, and they were going to be mad at her. She'd be a Bad Person. She leaned her head against the door and clamped her hands over her head to keep them from the doorknob.

I shall fear no evil because you're with me. Oh God, please be with me right now. This is the right thing, I know this is the right thing, you said what I do for the least I do for you so be here. Do it for Madison. They're your child. They deserve to be loved and cared for. Do not let them down. I don't care what your will is, you do not let them down, Adora said, feeling sweat pop up in her armpits in the cold of the apartment.

"She going to open up?" the other officer said.

"Ma'am, you going to open up?" the first officer said.

Adora prayed harder than she'd prayed in years, her eyes clamped shut.

"You think we kick it in?" the other officer said.

"Maybe," the first officer said and then knocked hard on the door again, the noise stunningly loud in Adora's head from where it rested against the door. "Ma'am, you hear that? That what you want?"

Adora almost answered then but then she heard the other officer say, “Ma’am, you need to move on.”

Adora almost fell to the floor when she heard Glimmer’s voice loud and clear say, “I will not. I am an attorney for the people in that apartment. Do you have a warrant?”

Adora almost smashed her face to the peephole and saw Glimmer standing there in a fluffy pink coat, her purple hair sticking out from the bottom of her matching pink stocking cap, looking up at both officers with an expression like an avenging angel. She had both of her hands held slightly out to the side so they could clearly see they were empty.

“Listen, move on or we’ll arrest you for interfering,” the first officer said.

Glimmer slowly turned over her right hand.

“This is my business card and I will see my clients now,” Glimmer said.

“Glimmer’s here,” Adora whispered over her shoulder quickly and she saw Catra sag a little in relief but the phone, and its video camera, stayed steady. Adora looked back out the peephole and saw that the first officer had taken the card and was looking at it.

“It’s a crime to impersonate an attorney,” the officer said.

“Then it’s a good thing I am one,” Glimmer said as her eyes flicked to his name badge. “Now are you going to move down the hall so I can get in there, Officer Dean?”

“No,” Officer Dean said as he handed the card to the other officer who went down the hall and began to talk on his radio again. “I’ll go in with you though.”

“Not without a warrant you won’t,” Glimmer said. “We can stand out here all night, it’s up to you, but I will go in there on my own.”

“Listen, maybe you don’t know what’s going on but this is a potential kidnapping situation,” Officer Dean said. “How about you tell me what’s been told to you and we can work this out.”

“No,” Glimmer said.

“Dean!” the other officer said from down the hall and Officer Dean turned around. The other officer was walking back and Adora could just see him gesturing. The two met and Glimmer stepped up to the door and knocked once. Adora opened the door quickly and Glimmer slipped in as the officers came rushing back. Glimmer slammed the door shut and locked the deadbolt.

“Oh, god damn, that was terrifying,” Glimmer said as Adora wrapped her up in her arms.

“Thank you, thank you, thank you,” Adora said.

“Don’t thank me yet,” Glimmer said as there was another pounding on the door.

Glimmer shed her coat and Adora was shocked to first see she was still in her pajama top above some sweatpants and second to see she had slung a laptop bag under her coat. Glimmer went over to the two and started talking as she hauled a folder out of her bag.

“Kaitlyn, I know you. Madison, I’m Glimmer Selene. I’m an attorney and if you want me to I will represent you pro bono. If you agree I need your signature on this paper,” Glimmer said as she pulled out a sheet of paper. Glimmer didn’t flinch when there was another pounding on the door but everyone else did.

“I… I don’t know,” Madison said. “I just want to stay away from my parents.”

“I understand,” Glimmer said. “It’s your choice either way but I will help you if you want.”

Madison looked at Kaitlyn who took their hand and nodded. Madison took the paper from Glimmer and looked at it.

"This is a basic contract between you and I saying I'll represent you as your attorney. Here is where my fee schedule would normally be. Note it's filled in with a zero," Glimmer said. Adora went back to the door and when she looked out she saw two more officers had arrived.

"Glimmer…," Adora said and Glimmer shook her hand behind her as she went on.

"This section lays out that I'll work in your best interest and follow your directions to the extent the law allows," Glimmer said. "The rest is basic contact information, billing information if there were any, and such. If you agree, fill in your full legal name there and there and sign there. Kaitlyn, print and sign as witness there, full legal name as well."

Madison looked at the paper and then looked up.

"I need a pen."

Glimmer pulled one out of her bag and handed it to them before pulling a few more documents out of her folder.

"The rest of you, I better get you as well," Glimmer said. "Get over here and sign. Catra and Adora, I've filled yours out already, I just need your signatures. Don't witness each others, Kaitlyn, you witness those as well. One of you witness Kaitlyn's as well."

"Glimmer, there are two more cops out there," Adora said.

"Don't worry about that. That's what I'm here for," Glimmer said. There was a moment of silence while people signed stuff. Glimmer had Catra take a picture of each one when they were fully filled out before picking each one up, looked at them one last time, ignoring the almost continual pounding on the door that was going on, before sticking them in the folder.

“Now what?” Kaitlyn said.

Glimmer took a deep breath before saying, “If the police come in or you have to talk to them, you say your name, your address, that you do not consent to a search and that you want to remain silent and talk to your attorney. Then shut your mouth and don’t say anything else no matter what they say. Name, address, that you don’t consent to a search, and you want to talk to your attorney, that’s it and you only say it once, clear and calm. Keep your hands in plain sight, don’t move fast, and don’t talk to them beyond what I told you to say. Understand?”

Catra and Adora had already heard all of this before but Kaitlyn and Madison just nodded.

“No, I want to hear you say you understand,” Glimmer said. “Name, address, that you don’t consent to a search, and you want to talk to your attorney and then you shut up. Understood?”

“Yes,” Kaitlyn and Madison both replied.

“OK, Kaitlyn, go to the bedroom, shut the door, and stay in there until I tell you otherwise,” Glimmer said.

“I want to stay with Madison,” Kaitlyn said.

“I strongly suggest you don’t for reasons I don’t want to get into right now,” Glimmer said. “She’s going to be with one of us.”

“They. Their pronouns are they,” Kaitlyn said mulishly.

“I’m sorry,” Glimmer said to Madison before turning back to Kaitlyn. “They’ll be with one of us.”

Kaitlyn looked at Madison who looked back at her and nodded as they chewed on the edge of the blanket they were wrapped in. Adora knew the shaking Madison had wasn’t because they were cold though because Adora had the same issue. Kaitlyn gave them a tight hug and then went to the bedroom and shut the door.

“Catra, put that hammer away,” Glimmer said, pointing at the hammer on the table. Catra quickly shoved it under a couch cushion as Glimmer gave a short snort and then flipped through the folder one last time. “Catra, stay with Madison. Adora, you’re coming with me.”

“Where?” Adora and Catra both said.

“Out into the hall,” Glimmer said.

“Absolutely not!” Catra said.

“Yes. I don’t want them bringing the tactical squad out here because they think it’s some barricade situation,” Glimmer said. “I have to talk with them, alright, and I want Adora by my side because she’s one of the occupants of the apartment but mainly because I am scared out of my mind right now.”

Catra was about to respond but finally just nodded.

“If we all get arrested it’s going to be hard to bail us out,” Catra said.

“No, it’s not,” Glimmer said. “Bow is in the car as our backup and emergency bail fund.”

Catra sighed as she said, “I always knew it would be him to bail me out.”

“Didn’t we all?” Glimmer said. “Did you get those pictures we talked about?”

“Yes,” Catra said and then they all suddenly looked up as the pounding stopped.

“Shit,” Glimmer said. “OK, Madison, do I have your permission to have Catra send that to my partner for safekeeping? His name is Bow Hart.”

Madison nodded and then suddenly said, “Yes.”

“Send ‘em,” Glimmer said to Catra. “That video you took too, as well as the forms. Alright, let’s go before that door comes off its hinges. Madison, lock the door behind us.”

Glimmer walked up to the door, her hands shaking a little before she took a deep breath and shouted, “I am coming out with one other person. Please move away from the door.”

She didn’t wait and cracked the door open before sliding out, Adora following right along. She looked up to see drawn guns and threw up a little in her mouth. Then she heard the door lock behind her and knew she was well and truly in it.

“Put your hands where we can see them!” Officer Dean shouted.

It was pointless to say because Adora had reflexively put her hands over her head. Glimmer just put her hands out in front of her and Adora saw a drop of sweat run down the back of her friend’s neck and she started praying again.

“I’m ready to speak with you,” Glimmer said, her voice calm.

“Get against the wall now!” Officer Dean said while one officer holstered his gun and pulled out cuffs and pepper spray.

“No,” Glimmer said and Adora was shocked that she could answer so calmly.

Adora saw an older cop walking down the hallway then. While the four in the hall facing her seemed like tension in polyester shirts, this officer seemed to walk almost fluidly, like he was taking all the time in the world and saw everything with just a glance.

“Lieutenant,” one of the officers said as he got up to them.

“Gentleman,” the lieutenant replied. “What’s going on?”

“We’re taking these two into custody,” Officer Dean said.

“Which one claims to be the attorney?” the lieutenant said.

"I am," Glimmer said, not moving.

"I'd like to talk with you," he said. "If you'll come with me."

"No. We can talk right here," Glimmer said and Adora saw the lieutenant's face get a little irritated for a moment but went on like it was no big deal.

"I'm Lieutenant Markham," he said. "You are?"

"Glimmer Selene," Glimmer replied. Adora was relieved to see weapons being put up and the other officers not necessarily relaxing but definitely calming down a little and she took the chance to lower her arms. "I'm the attorney for this woman, Adora Manzana."

"Why are you holding up my officers?" Markham asked.

"I'm doing nothing of the sort. They tried to gain entry to this apartment without a warrant. My client simply stated she wouldn't talk to them or let them in without it," Glimmer said. "If they have questions, they can ask and I will advise my client."

Markham gave a little smile, a smile that said he was going to humor Glimmer but for how long only he knew, as he said, "We're looking for a teenager named Madison Keel. She left her home tonight and her parents believe she was taken under duress. You know anything about that Ms. Manzana?"

Adora looked at Glimmer who gave a short head shake before saying, "Why do you suspect they're here?"

"We have our ways," Markham replied and Adora began to go from terrified to angry at his attitude. "Also, someone reported seeing her here."

Adora was confused. Madison had arrived so late at night she wondered who'd seen them and then thought to call the police. Glimmer nodded as she said, "They are here. I think you should

involve Child Protective Services immediately. They have bruises and I suspect possible child abuse."

"I want to talk with her alone. We'll decide if CPS needs to be here or not," Markham said.

"I'm representing them as well," Glimmer said. "You can talk with them while I'm present."

"Why do you keep saying them?" Markham asked.

"Because it's their preferred pronouns," Glimmer said. Adora heard one of the officers to her side snort in derision but did her best not to react.

"I'll keep that in mind," Markham said. "Now let's go in and talk with her."

"I'll bring them out," Glimmer said and Adora could almost hear her gritting her teeth.

Glimmer knocked on the door and Adora heard Catra respond with a what and realized her wife had probably been standing just on the other side of the door.

"Madison needs to come out and speak with the officers," Glimmer said.

After a moment, the door cracked open and Madison came out, still wrapped in the blanket off the couch. The bright fuzzy blanket in vibrant blue and orange shades seemed off kilter in the tense air of the hall.

"Madison, these officers need to ask you a few questions," Glimmer said. "I'm here to help you with that, alright?"

"We're not doing this right here," Markham said. "I'm not letting anyone influence her."

Adora did her best to not look away when Markham looked straight at her.

“I understand,” Glimmer said. She looked at Adora for a moment but didn’t say anything before Markham, her, Madison, and another officer walked down the hall. Two other officers stood behind her and Adora could just overhear them talking about how uncomfortable the county jail was and how they were glad they didn't even have to go in, much less be a prisoner there. None of them tried to talk to her directly and Adora tried to watch down the hall but they ended up in the stairwell and she couldn’t see anything. Finally, after what seemed an eternity, the four came back.

Adora felt a lump in her throat because she could see that Madison had been crying again when they stopped at the door. Something seemed to happen between the other officers and two of them left, leaving just Officer Dean and his partner with Markham. Adora heard a burst of conversation over that officer’s radios as he walked away that was full of jargon and acronyms she didn’t understand but she caught the word CPS before the officer turned his radio down.

“OK, CPS is on their way it sounds like,” Markham said before looking at Adora. “You should have just led with what I just heard and all of this trouble could have been avoided. You know that you’ll have to let them in, right?”

“I’ll discuss it with them when they arrive,” Glimmer said.

“You know, I know how long you’ve been a lawyer,” Markham said. “You’re being pretty bold.”

“Just doing my job,” Glimmer said.

“As are we,” Markham said.

Adora wanted to say that pounding on the door, pulling guns on people, and threatening them wasn’t a great way to resolve anything but she literally bit her lip to keep from speaking up.

Glimmer though just gave a tight smile as she replied, “Of course.”

They all stood in the hallway, not saying anything, for almost half an hour. Adora was sure she could hear Catra on the other side of the door slowly seething. Glimmer occasionally pulled her phone out of her pocket, tapped a few things on it, before putting it away, looking all the time like she was right where she wanted to be. Madison huddled between Adora and Glimmer. Adora could hear them occasionally take a breath, like they wanted to say something and then thought better of it, and wondered how long before they spoke up.

Finally, Adora looked up and saw a woman in a long coat, sweatpants, and a sweatshirt coming down the hall carrying a big messenger bag. She looked about as tired as Adora did with a side of irritation thrown in for good measure. The other officer, who Adora had managed to see on his name badge was named Reynaud, turned as she approached. She didn’t even say anything as she held out a big ID card hanging around her neck. Adora could see her picture and the seal of their state on it as well as some words she assumed said who she was and her agency.

“Fran, good to see you,” Officer Reynaud replied.

“Why are we doing this right now?” Fran said, looking around. “It’s the middle of the damn night. Why didn’t you just take her into protective custody? We could have dealt with this in the morning.”

Three sets of eyes fell on Glimmer as Officer Reynaud gave a little thumb gesture at Glimmer.

“She’s got legal representation,” Officer Reynaud said with a little sneer.

Glimmer stepped forward, another card almost magically appearing in her hand, as she held it out to Fran.

“Ma’am, my name is Glimmer Selene and Mx. Keel has retained my services,” Glimmer said.

Fran raised an eyebrow, although Adora couldn’t say at what, as she took the card from Glimmer and looked it over before shoving it into a pocket of her bag and pulling out a notepad and pen. She flipped over the cover as she said, “I’m Fran Betlewski. I work for Child Protective Services and I’m here because of reports of abuse. Are you Madison Keel?”

Madison looked at Glimmer who gave her a little smile and nod.

“Yes, ma’am, I am.”

Fran made a note before saying, “Madison, normally these officers would take you into protective custody and we’d work through the process from there.” Glimmer started to speak up and Fran shot a look at her as she cut her off. “However, we seem to be playing off the normal playbook as it were and I’ll do my best. Which of you officers can give me a short rundown here?”

Lieutenant Markham nodded at Officer Reynaud, who’d gone down the hall with them when they’d questioned Madison, and he gave a short retelling that sounded like he was already writing the report. Adora found herself tearing up as she heard a fuller description of what had happened, especially since it was couched in such cold terms and she also noticed that how Madison had come to be at their apartment was pretty vague. Fran took notes, stopping just once to ask a question. When Officer Reynaud finished, Fran continued writing for a moment before looking at Madison and asking a question.

“This is not a guarantee but do you wish to ever return to your parent’s home?”

Adora’s heart broke because she saw the uncertainty that warred on Madison’s face for a moment. She knew how that was because even while you knew that it was a bad idea, even while you knew they weren’t good people and returning was not in your interest,

to return was to go back to something you knew, something familiar and even almost comfortable, and the lure was strong. In the other direction was uncertainty. The unknowing if anything would ever feel familiar or comfortable again and with the strong feeling that you would regret every moment to come. You could see the chance of maybe, possibly, something better but the unknown overshadowed everything and it was, in a word, terrifying. Adora had been there. Adora had faced it but she had faced it with friends. Madison was facing it with complete strangers in a hostile situation.

Madison looked at the ground when the question was asked and their response was quiet enough that Fran had to gently ask them to repeat themself.

"No," they said, finally looking up with the expression of a person who thought they were walking to meet Death but were going to do it staring it in the face the whole way.

Fran nodded as she made another note before saying, "Very well. You'll need to come with me so we can find you a place to stay while this gets worked out."

Adora spoke up before Glimmer could get a word in.

"They can stay here," Adora said. "My wife and I are more than prepared to take care of them as long as necessary."

Madison was looking at Adora in surprise and Fran just sighed as the officers shifted a little in the hallway.

"You know you can't just take her in," Fran said. "I don't even know your name."

Glimmer replied, "She's a client as well and her name is Adora Manzana. Ms. Betlewski, it's late at night. If you take them to some facility you'll be out all night. I can vouch for Ms. Manzana and her wife's credibility and stability. I can also vouch we'll all be here bright and early in the morning for you to come by and deal with all of the paperwork I'm sure this requires."

Fran was about to speak when Madison suddenly spoke up, their voice quiet but with a hard edge under it, “I’m they/them.”

Everyone looked at them and Adora heard Officer Dean snicker a little and she saw Lieutenant Markham roll his eyes but Madison, even though they were still hunched in on themself, had fire in their eyes now.

“I’m sorry?” Fran said.

Madison shrunk back a little, as if they were expecting a blow, but their eyes still burned as they said, “My pronouns are they/them. You keep calling me she. All of you but Glimmer and Adora do. Do it right.”

Fran nodded before making a note on her pad.

“I apologize, I didn’t make the connection,” Fran said. “Still, I’m not sure if I should leave them here. I don’t know anything about your backgrounds at all. I have no idea what kind of home you keep.”

Glimmer said, “Let’s work this out then. What kind of assurance would you need?”

Fran looked between them, trying to think of a solution, before saying, “If you’ll allow these officers to run a quick warrant and background check through their dispatch and I can conduct a quick home study, I’ll allow it for tonight. Tomorrow is tomorrow though.”

“Isn’t it though,” Glimmer said with a little smile that Adora was a bit surprised to see Fran return. Glimmer turned to Adora and went on. “Is it alright if Ms. Betlewski comes into your home?”

Adora nodded and then realized she should probably respond as she said, “Yes, I grant her permission.”

“We’ll come in for your safety,” Officer Dean said.

Before Adora or Glimmer could speak, Fran shook her head as she said, "No, thank you. Just run those checks for me and we'll be alright."

"There's other people in there you know," Officer Reynaud said. "Notice they didn't tell you that."

Glimmer said, "I'll get Adora's wife."

Madison was looking around between everyone, taking it all in. Adora could see that they recognized that they were in the whirlwind now but in their eyes that they were determined to ride it.

Glimmer knocked on the door and Adora heard Catra's muffled voice ask what and Glimmer said, "Come on out here for a moment please."

There was a pause and then Catra came out, keeping the door close to her before pulling it closed and locking it before turning around and shooting looks of pure venom at the officers. She didn't say anything but Adora had a feeling that might not last and that not lasting would probably be measured in seconds.

"You lock your door when you're going to be standing right outside?" Lieutenant Markham asked.

"You never know who's around," Catra said and Adora bit her lip, feeling at least a little vindicated that she knew her wife well.

"Catrina," Glimmer said, ignoring the look Catra gave her for using her birth name as she set a hand on Catra, "Ms. Fran Betlewski here works for CPS. She needs some basic information from you so these officers can run some basic background. This is so that Madison can stay here tonight with an eye towards making that permanent. Do you agree to this?"

"Yeah," Catra said.

The next few minutes had Catra slip back into the apartment to get their ID's and then waiting as Officer Dean called it in. Lieutenant Markham leaned against the wall, his face neutral as he watched everything, and Officer Reynaud had his arms locked behind him as he watched the whole thing. Finally, the dispatcher read back that everything was clear.

"Officers, I have it from here. I'll call if I need you again," Fran said as she took the ID's and handed them back to Catra and Adora.

"You don't know what you're walking into in there," Officer Reynaud replied. Fran replied with a cool smile.

"Thank you for your concern, officer, but I do it every day and I do it unarmed. Thank you for your help tonight."

Lieutenant Markham nodded as he said, "Officers, I think we're done here. Ms. Betlewski can handle anything I'm sure. Follow me on out to the cars."

Both the officers nodded and followed him down the hall and Madison watched them go before turning to Fran.

"You're really not going to take me to jail?"

"No. Even if I did have to take you with me, where you'd go is not a jail," Fran said.

"My parents always said if I acted up too much, CPS would take me to jail," Madison said.

Fran's eyes narrowed a little but just said, "Well, let's look at this apartment, alright?"

Chapter End Notes

> Please note, I am not a lawyer. I have looked up a lot of this because I want it to be somewhat accurate but do not take my word for anything legal related. This did not start out as a

kind of legal thriller. It was more going to be about Catra and Adora helping someone out. But I've written part of what is going to be the final story in this series and Glimmer is a lawyer there by then and I thought, "The timeframe you're looking at fits just at the time she's going to have been finishing law school and taking the bar. I think you can work with that." Thus, Glimmer Selene, attorney-at-law.

I'll also say when I started it, it was more of a, "I need to work on Illusions but I have this idea for a fic in the Camp Bright Moon series. I'm going to in, write the first paragraph or so, make a few notes, and then go work on Illusions."

Four and half hours later I realized I had written just shy of six thousand words and it was midnight. As I've said before, sometimes writing is a sludge but sometimes it's flying on silver wings. This also was supposed to be a short fic. I apparently don't do that kind of thing anymore. Anyway, chapter one, hope you enjoy this! I will say this isn't going to be some huge book length fic. Probably. At least I hope not. I've already got one of those in progress and I don't need another.

Chapter Two

Chapter Summary

> Catra and Adora have managed to get around the police but now they have to deal with the social worker. Will Fran be an ally or an enemy?

Chapter Notes

> Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra unlocked the door and let everyone in. Adora felt like the whole place should be changed, that nothing should look the same, but it was just their apartment. Old furniture, her crystals hanging in the window where they'd catch the light and throw rainbows around the room, various little bits of ironwork art that Catra had made, and some knick-knacks and plants.

"Now, first thing first, where is Madison going to sleep?" Fran asked.

Everyone looked at Glimmer who said, "Go ahead and answer her questions. I'll stop you if need be."

"You know if you stop me from completing this, they come with me," Fran said and then took a deep breath as she felt the anger in the room flare. "Listen, sorry, that wasn't supposed to be so confrontational. It's a rough night, I know, but I'm trying to help you out here."

“I understand,” Adora said. “And thank you.”

“Alright,” Glimmer said. “Fair enough but I’m still looking after all my client’s interests.”

“I assume that includes Catrina?” Fran said.

“Yes,” Glimmer said.

“And call me Catra,” Catra said.

“Noted,” Fran said. “Now, back to the first question. Where is Madison going to sleep?”

“They can sleep in our bed,” Catra said and then realized how that sounded as she quickly went on. “We’ll sleep out here.”

Fran nodded as she said, “It can be on a couch for now if the couch is sound. Do you have blankets and pillows for them?”

And that began about half an hour of investigation and questions. They showed her the photos from earlier and Fran asked a few questions of Madison. Then Madison sat on the edge of the couch

as Catra and Adora showed Fran the kitchen and the food they had there.

"That's adequate for tonight and tomorrow morning but you need to fill it up more and make sure there are different kinds of snacks as well, including some fresh fruit," Fran said.

Fran asked if they had running water and Adora said they did.

"Prove it."

Catra raised a little eyebrow but turned on the faucet as she replied, "Ta-da."

Fran's lips twitched a little as she made another note. She walked around the small kitchen and living room, gave the windows a little tug, and made more notes.

"Most of what I'm checking doesn't really apply since Madison is older but I want it checked off anyway because of the situation," Fran said as they checked the thermostat for a moment. "Now I just need to check the bedroom and bathroom."

"Um, before you go in there…," Adora started to say and Fran stopped her.

“I don’t care if it’s messy or that your underwear is on the ground. Do you have something illegal in there?” Fran said. “Tell me now if you do.”

Adora looked to Catra who looked to Glimmer who looked back at them before saying, “There’s someone in there.”

Fran folded her arms and raised an eyebrow but didn’t say anything.

“She’s a friend of Catra and Adora,” Glimmer said and Adora wanted to applaud the phrasing. “She doesn’t live here, there’s nothing that’s wrong but we just didn’t want her to get tangled up in this.”

Adora wondered why Madison hadn’t said anything and she turned to see Madison leaned up against the back of the couch, their mouth hanging open a little as they slept with the blanket pulled tight across their chest. Fran turned and saw the same thing before looking back at the other three.

“In the end, what I care about is them,” Fran said, her voice getting a little quieter as they pointed at Madison. “You all seem to be decent people so I am ignoring this one thing. Do not make me regret it or I swear I will make you regret it as well.”

“Understood,” Glimmer said.

Adora stepped forward and opened the bedroom door to see Kaitlyn curled up on the bed asleep. As soon as the door opened though, she startled awake and Adora moved aside so she could see Fran.

"Kaitlyn, this is Fran," Catra quickly said. "She's here to help the person who showed up tonight and she's checking out the apartment to be sure it's suitable for them to stay."

Adora was relieved to see Kaitlyn just nod as she didn't see Glimmer standing behind Fran making hush gestures. Fran wasn't completely clueless though as she looked at Catra, having picked up on how quick Catra had filled Kaitlyn in on the official story, and said, "One. That's it."

"I understand," Catra said.

Fran checked the bedroom and then bathroom, Adora a bit embarrassed for the latter even though it was clean, and came back out, shutting the door on Kaitlyn.

"OK, final questions," Fran said. "Any firearms?"

"No," Catra and Adora both answered in unison.

“Do either of you use illegal drugs or have any in the apartment?”

“No.”

Fran made another note then reviewed the couple of pages she’d filled up for a moment before putting it away.

“Alright, I’m granting permission for Madison to stay here for tonight,” Fran said. “Tomorrow, I expect you two and Madison to come to the main CPS office at 9am. There is a lot to sort out.”

“I’ll be with them,” Glimmer said.

Fran gave a little grin again as she said, “I expected nothing less.” Her grin evaporated though as she went on. “I need those photos you took as well. That’s going to be my leverage in this I think.”

“They’re that bad?” Adora whispered in surprise.

Fran got a haunted look for a moment as she said, “Not from what I’ve seen before but they’ll help.” She looked away for a second and when she looked back, her face was back to normal. “Nine in the morning. Sharp.”

“Understood,” Catra said.

“And thank you,” Adora said.

“Don’t thank me,” Fran said. “The system is not great but I’ll do what I can. You may end up hating me before this is all over.”

“I hope not,” Adora said.

“So do I,” Fran said and started for the door before stopping with her hand on the knob. “And off the record, tell Kaitlyn she is not to stay over here tonight or any other night for that matter.”

“Can do,” Catra said.

“Good night,” Fran said and went out the door.

Catra went over and locked it before sliding down the door to the floor.

“God damn, that fucking sucked,” Catra said.

Glimmer was furiously typing on her phone as she said, “I played so fast and loose tonight, you have no idea.”

“What do you mean?” Adora said as she sat down next to Catra and put her arm around her.

“I don’t really know family law that well,” Glimmer said as she put her phone away and sat down against the wall by them. “I’m not even 100% that the contract with Madison is legit.”

“What?” Catra said, sitting up a little straighter.

“They’re underage,” Glimmer said. “I think it’s doable but I don’t really remember that part of contract law. It doesn’t come up much.”

Catra and Adora looked at Glimmer in wide eyed surprise before Catra suddenly grinned ear-to-ear as she said, “Sparkles, that is the ballsiest thing I have ever seen you do.”

Glimmer lay down on the floor as she said, “Do not remind me. I kept thinking, ‘Oh God, I’m going to get debarred right after I passed it.’”

“Well you were amazing,” Adora said. “I can’t believe you faced those cops down like that.”

They all looked over as the bedroom door cracked open a little and Kaitlyn looked out as she said, “Is everyone gone?”

“Yeah,” Catra said. “Madison is asleep on the couch and you can’t stay here.”

“I know, I was listening at the door,” Kaitlyn said. “I’ll head back to my dorm in a few.”

She walked into the living room, stepping over Glimmer’s feet as she did, and looked at Madison.

“You really don’t know them, do you?” Adora said.

Kaitlyn shook her head as she said, “I helped out in the youth group that they were in right before I left the church when I came out. My parents figured that we needed to go elsewhere. I guess they remembered me and my story. When they called they were frantic.” Kaitlyn stopped and stared at Madison and Adora could see several emotions struggling on her face. “I barely remembered them but they called on me. What was I going to do? Say no?”

“A lot of people would have,” Glimmer said.

“Yeah, well, I couldn’t. When I found them, their parents had already shut off their cell phone,” Kaitlyn said. “They said it

happened right after they got off the phone with me. I'm sorry for dragging you into this but I didn't know where to turn. Figured you'd be able to help but I didn't think that all of that would happen. I owe you so much."

"Don't worry about it," Catra said. "You don't owe us a thing."

"That's right," Adora said.

Everyone fell into silence again and then Catra and Adora were startled when they heard a key in the lock. They got out of the way as Bow came in, dressed in a coat and sweatpants. He looked down at Glimmer sprawled out on the ground.

"Did you kill my girlfriend?"

"I'm fine, sweetie," Glimmer said, giving a thumbs up. "It's been an eventful night."

"Your girlfriend there is a badass," Catra said as Kaitlyn sat down in the door to the bedroom.

Bow sat down next to Glimmer and took her hand. He began to gently stroke the top of it as he said, "I'm well aware. Now what?"

“We have to be at the CPS main office at 9am,” Glimmer said.

“Why?” Bow replied.

“Because those two stepped up to help Madison over there on the couch,” Glimmer said. Bow looked at Glimmer with a little knowing grin and she rolled her eyes. “Yes, you were right. I’ll pay up later.”

“Very well,” Bow said.

“You bet on whether we were going to help!?” Adora said.

“No, I bet on whether or not you’d end up in jail,” Bow said.

“You bet we would?” Kaitlyn said to Glimmer.

“Hey, I believe I said I played fast and loose tonight,” Glimmer said. “Let’s not focus on that, alright?”

“Let’s focus on the fact it’s four in the morning and you have to be at an office at 9am,” Bow said. “Plan?”

“I’m going to bed in a few,” Catra said.

“I am as well,” Adora said.

Kaitlyn stood up as she said, “I better get out of here. Tell Madison I’ll be by tomorrow, alright?”

“We will,” Adora said as they got up off the ground. The four gathered and hugged Kaitlyn tight.

“You did good,” Glimmer said.

“I sat in a room,” Kaitlyn said as she wiped at her tears.

“That wasn’t all you did,” Catra said. “You did good.”

Kaitlyn walked to the door and Bow asked, “Do you need a ride home? Are you OK to drive?”

Kaitlyn nodded before she said, “Worse case, I’ll sleep in the car.”

“Let us know when you get home,” Adora said and Kaitlyn agreed before leaving. Catra went over and shut off the lamp that she’d

turned on back when everything had all begun. Adora felt like it had been days but she knew it had only been a couple of hours. Bow disappeared into the bedroom and came back out with a pillow and set it on the couch next to Madison before joining the other four by the door.

"OK, we're going to stay here tonight," Glimmer said. "Adora, I'll need to borrow some clothes in the morning."

"You mean in a few hours?" Catra said.

"Let me have the illusion we're going to get some sleep please," Glimmer replied.

"I've got an alarm set for 6:30," Bow said. "I'll make sure everyone is up."

"That's only…, you know what, I'm going to pretend I don't know how close that is," Catra said before taking Adora's hand. "Come on."

Adora and Catra went to their bedroom. Glimmer curled up on a loveseat and Bow took the old recliner. Even though they all felt wired, they all fell asleep pretty quick, only to be woken up only minutes later by Bow. At least that's what it felt like.

"Come on, up and at 'em," Bow said softly as he shook Adora.

She woke up to hear Catra already sliding off the bed, muttering under her breath.

"What time is it?" Adora said.

"It's almost 6:30," Bow replied.

"You said 6:30 was when the alarm was for," Adora groaned as she sat up.

"I woke up a bit early. Figured a few extra minutes getting ready couldn't hurt," Bow said. "Come on, get up. It's going to be a busy day and I still have to get Glimmer up."

Having roomed with Glimmer through most of her early college years, Adora did not envy Bow that task. She put her feet on the ground, memories of making campers do that when she was a counselor to prove they were at least upright flashing past, as she said, "OK, feet on the ground. I'm up."

Bow nodded and left the room. Catra was already in the shower as Adora grabbed some clothes for both of them and threw Catra's set on the bed. She walked out in her pajamas from the night before, Glimmer passing her with a grunt as she went into the bedroom, to see Madison laying down on the couch. Their

eyes were open and when they saw Adora they quietly asked, "Where's Kaitlyn?"

"Fran said she couldn't stay last night," Adora said. "We promised her we'll let her know what's going on and we'll see about meeting up with her again today."

"What's happening now?" Madison said.

Adora sat down as she heard Bow rummaging in the fridge and said, "We have to go to the CPS office by 9am. All of us are going to go, you're not in this alone."

Madison sat up, brushing their black hair back out of their eyes, and then pulled the blanket tight around themself.

"Do you have any spare clothes in your duffel?" Adora said, nodding at the bag on the ground.

"That's not mine," Madison said. "Kaitlyn had it with her when she picked me up. The only thing I had was my cell phone and what I'm wearing."

Adora fought down the surge of anger as she nodded.

“Let’s go through it,” Adora said as she heard Bow start cooking something. “Bow will have breakfast in a few minutes I bet and the bathroom will be available in a few too.”

Bow spoke up from the kitchen and said, “Let me know if you don’t like something, I’ll get you something else.”

Madison picked up the duffel and fiddled with it for a moment before unzipping it. Adora saw that Kaitlyn must have thrown things inside in a mad rush as it was a bunch of shirts, a pair of jeans, and some mismatched socks. Adora was already going over their finances in her head as she thought of various things that Madison was going to need.

“Pick out as much as you can,” Adora said. “I’ll go see if the shower is ready yet.”

As she left the room again, Madison picked through the bag, pulling out a t-shirt with the logo of an aquarium on it and the pair of jeans. They were looking at the socks when Bow brought a frying pan full of scrambled eggs to the table, along with some toast.

“It’s ready if you want it,” Bow said. “And we didn’t get properly introduced. My name is Bow Hart, pronouns he/him. Glimmer is my girlfriend.”

Madison looked at him for a moment before quietly saying, “You, uh, you don’t have to do that.”

“I don’t mind cooking,” Bow said with a grin. “Trust me, of the four of us, I’m the one you want doing it.”

Madison shook their head as they said, “No, I mean the pronoun thing. It’s alright.”

Bow sat down at the little table as he said, “It’s important to me and it’s not just about you. I’m trans as well.”

Madison stopped from where they were laying out socks, trying to make a match, and looked over at Bow.

“Really?”

Bow smiled at their expression of surprise as he said, “Yes, really.”

Madison picked up two socks and set them on the t-shirt they’d picked out.

“You alright?” Bow asked.

Madison just nodded and got up and sat down at the table. Bow didn't push and got up to get some plates and flatware. Madison managed to eat a little as the rest of the group came out, dressed for the day, Glimmer in a mix of Adora and Catra's clothes, and settled down at the table. Glimmer just responded with grunts to any questions and Catra just stared sleepily off into the distance as she sipped at some milk as Adora shoveled in most of the food. Madison finally stood up, plate and flatware in hand, and said, "May I please be excused to take a shower?"

The four stopped and looked at them. Adora picked up on it quickly, recognizing something of her own upbringing in the moment, as she said, "Yeah, that's fine. And you don't have to ask to be excused, OK?"

Madison just nodded and put their dishes in the sink before picking up the clothes they'd picked out before leaving the room and shutting the bedroom door. Glimmer spoke up, her voice tired as she said, "Oh, glee, it's going to be like breaking Adora of calling every adult ma'am or sir all over."

"Hey, that wasn't that hard," Adora said and then chose to ignore the three sets of eyes giving her a look.

"What's the plan?" Catra said.

"We need to leave soon," Glimmer said. "When we get there, I'll try and do as much talking as possible. I think Fran is wanting to help us and she's bending rules to make it happen but we can't

push her. I've got to ask as well, you sure you can take care of Madison?"

Catra looked at Adora, who was looking right back at her, before Catra turned back and said, "Yeah. We'll manage."

"Because there's options," Glimmer said. "We can maybe get them with Mom and Dad."

"Maybe ask your parents before you drop someone on them," Bow said.

"At least it'd be just one this time and they can stay in your bedroom since you moved out," Catra said with a little smirk.

"Listen, I think we can handle it," Adora said. "We'll be a bit cramped here but we'll get it all figured out."

"While you're in the meeting today, I'll start hitting people up," Bow said. "See what we can shake loose for aid."

"Isn't it supposed to be a day off for you?" Adora said.

"Hey, I went to work for the foundation because I like this kind of thing," Bow said.

“Contact Kaitlyn,” Adora said. “I bet she’ll want to help and we kind of had to cut her out last night.”

Bow nodded as he said, “Can do.”

They chatted for a few more minutes before finishing up. Catra gathered up the dishes and gave them a quick rinse while Glimmer pulled out her computer from her laptop bag. Adora went over and knocked on the bedroom door.

“Madison, we have to leave soon. You about ready?” Adora heard something muttered and waited to see if there was more before she went on. “I couldn’t hear you.”

“Could you come in?”

Adora cracked the door and stuck her head in. The overhead light was on and Adora saw Madison sitting on the edge of the bed. They were dressed in the clothes that they’d picked out, all of them a bit baggy since Kaitlyn was a bit bigger. Their long hair was damp and they seemed lost. Adora fought back the urge to ask if they were alight and stepped inside.

“What’s up?”

“Do you have a hair tie, ma’am?” Madison said.

Adora’s hair was currently cut short with an undercut but Catra’s hair was a big bush so Adora nodded as she went to the bathroom. She found one in a drawer and came back out and handed it to Madison. They took it and began to gather their hair together. The fire from the night before that had been in their eyes for a little bit wasn’t there at the moment and Adora thought they just looked like what they were, a scared person who didn’t know what the next moment was going to bring.

“OK, Glimmer said when we go that she’ll do most of the talking where necessary,” Adora said as she tried to not look at the bruise on their wrist or another further up their arm. “We’re planning on letting you stay here for as long as you want and that’s what we’re going to work towards if that’s what you want.”

Madison finished putting their hair up as they looked at Adora.

“I don’t know. I just… I know I can be a problem. I don’t want to be a problem,” Madison said as they suddenly wiped at their eyes. “I’m sorry. I shouldn’t have called Kaitlyn.”

“Hey, you’re not a problem,” Adora said, kneeling down and taking Madison’s hand. “I’m glad we can help. I know Kaitlyn is glad she could help. There’s things I regret but I’ll never regret helping someone.”

“You don’t understand,” Madison said as they wiped at their eyes with their free hand. “I know I’m a freak but I thought I could maybe hide it and now God is punishing me.”

“Hey, no, don’t say that, you’re not a freak,” Adora said. “You’re a child of God and they love you.”

Madison looked at Adora with doubt smeared across their face.

“I’ve heard about you,” Madison said. “Why would you say that?”

“That you’re not a freak? Because you’re not,” Adora said.

“No, the stuff about God,” Madison said.

Adora wondered what the stories were about her and Catra that Kaitlyn had referred to the night before and swore she’d get them out of her tonight. For now she stayed focused.

“Because I still believe,” Adora said. “I just don’t believe like I was raised to believe. I believe in things like Psalm 139 that says we’re fearfully and wonderfully made and that God knows your inner substance and loves you.”

Adora wrestled with her faith most days but right now, she was certain as she looked into Madison's eyes. She didn't even pretend to know what God wanted usually but she believed that God was expressed as love in the world for all of creation.

"You really think so?" Madison said, softly.

"Yes," Adora said, nodding and then an idea flashed in. "Would it help if we prayed before we went?"

Madison wiped at her eyes again as they said yes.

"Alright, you want me to say it?"

Madison nodded and Adora bowed her head and closed her eyes. It felt odd to try and pray because, notwithstanding the night before, it was something she rarely did anymore. She was nervous for a moment but as she took a deep breath the words came to her.

"Lord, I come to you today to pray for your child, Madison. They are your precious child, fearfully and wonderfully made, and just starting to discover the glorious mystery of exactly how you wove them together. Now, as Jonah did, they are crying out from the depths as they look for your face. Reach down and grant them discernment that they may make the best decisions for themself. Grant them courage to face the trials before them. Most importantly, clothe them in your love so that they may know that

they are loved and not alone," Adora said, pausing for a moment as she wanted to say what she'd thought the night before about how she didn't care if it wasn't part of God's plan. She cut that off though and wrapped it up. "I pray this in your name. Amen."

Adora opened her eyes and looked up to see Madison with their head still down, tears streaming down their face, as they softly said amen several more times. When they opened their eyes again, Adora wouldn't say she saw fire but there were at least a few coals in them.

"Ready?" Adora asked.

Madison nodded and they stood up and went into the living room.

Chapter End Notes

> Fun little story, that moment with the water faucet and Catra saying, "Ta-da!" comes directly from personal experience. My wife and I went through a CPS home study to be able to take in some family members on the weekend who were in CPS custody. The worker asked if we had running water. I said yes and she said, "Prove it."
>
> I, thinking the whole thing was a bit weird already, figured it wouldn't hurt to put a little pizzazz on showing her. I turned on the faucet, held my hand out like I was revealing a magic trick and went, "Ta-da!" Thankfully the worker had a sense of humor about it.
>
> Anyway, it was interesting touching on Adora and her faith about six years post-Camp Horde for the Lord. It's something that she's never going to lose I think but it is something that

is drastically and radically changed from what she started with. She's still chasing what it means, ever refining, and probably will until the day she dies.

Anyway, I hope you enjoyed this chapter and thank you for reading!

Chapter Three

Chapter Summary

The group goes to the CPS office to find out what their decision is going to be.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The ride in the car was quiet. They'd got on the road right as rush hour was starting up and getting out of the college town that Catra and Adora lived in was a bit of a chore because of the weird road setup but Bow handled it well. Madison sat in the back seat behind Bow and stared out of the window most of the way. Glimmer spent most of the time pulling up stuff on her computer and it was only as they were about ten minutes out from the CPS office that she packed it away and turned in her seat to look at the three in the back seat.

"I'm still buckled in," Glimmer commented to Bow. "Alright… Adora, wake up Catra. Alright, I think at this point, I think when we get in to see Fran, I expect we're going to be there a while. Bow, since you're still in your pajamas essentially, after you drop us off, go and get changed at the house if you want. Will you come back and wait outside?

"Of course," Bow said as he got off the highway.

“We’re going to be about twenty minutes early but that’s fine,” Glimmer said. “I don’t know what to expect honestly but none of us have done anything wrong so keep it simple. Madison, just clearly state what you want and answer questions short and to the point. Catra and Adora, I expect they’ll want to conduct a full background check on both of you. I know neither of you will have an issue passing.”

“What about that illegal weasel breeding ring I run?” Catra said. Madison’s eyes snapped over to Catra when she said illegal and then actually gave a short laugh when they heard the rest.

“Well, you haven’t been caught at it yet so just keep it under your hat,” Glimmer said. “Madison, do you have any questions?”

Madison shook their head as they said, “No, ma’am.”

Glimmer looked at Adora for a moment who just gave her a look back as they passed a hospital complex and started past some older stately homes in various stages of renovation. The state capitol building sat a few blocks up and Bow spoke up as they got close.

“Almost there.”

Glimmer nodded as she sat back down and said, “Don’t worry. OK, we’re all going to worry, but try not to. After this is over, I’m

taking us out for a decent lunch and then we're going back to our house to take a freaking nap."

"Better words have not been spoken," Catra said.

Bow drove past the capitol and down a road that ran behind it. He passed a museum and then pulled into the parking lot of the CPS building. Adora couldn't help but think the building looked like the very definition of bureaucracy with its plain facade and utilitarian landscaping as Bow pulled into a parking spot. Glimmer was giving little jumps in the seat while she waved her hands a bit.

"You know, psyching yourself up right before we go in isn't the encouragement you think it is," Catra said.

"Hush," Glimmer said and then got out of the car. Madison got out as well and Adora followed Catra out.

Catra stared at the building for a moment before taking a long breath and letting it out.

"You alright?" Adora asked as Madison came around.

"Yeah, I'll be alright," Catra said. "Just a lot of bad memories tangled up in this place."

With those words it occurred to Adora that Catra, having been in the foster system for years, probably wasn't having the best of times with this.

"You want to talk about it?" Adora said.

"Right before we have to go in? No. Besides, it's not the same," Catra said. Adora gave her a hug anyway as they started walking.

With the three gathered around them, Madison walked into the building looking like they had their own bodyguard squad. Inside was a waiting room about half full with families. Glimmer went right up to the receptionist with a smile and said, "Hello, my name is Glimmer Selene and I'm here with some clients to see Fran Betlewski at 9am."

The receptionist looked up with a tired expression as he said, "OK, sign in on the pad there, have a seat, and I'll let her know you're here."

Madison sat between Adora and Glimmer, looking around in silence. Adora expected a room with as many little kids as she saw to be louder but, for the most part, they seemed subdued as well, although there were a few making noise. The whole room was haunted by the faint scent of bleach, like a sanitary ghost drifting past occasionally, and the lights were just a bit too bright up by the desk while back in a corner of the waiting room it was dimmer because it didn't have any light fixtures. The walls were painted in a flat eggshell color and a few posters talking about various services and health programs were tacked up around the room.

“Nice to see they fixed it up a little,” Catra said softly. Adora looked at her in surprise. Catra looked back at her and shrugged. “Used to be this hideous orange-brown color and back in that dark corner they had a play area set up with old, donated toys. It was grim.”

Adora leaned over so just Catra could hear as she said, “What do you mean *was* grim?”

Catra shrugged again and went back to looking around the room. Adora looked over to Madison who had the corner of her coat in their mouth, gently gnawing at it. Adora wasn’t sure what to say so she just sat back and took a deep breath and let it out.

“We’ve been sitting for like three minutes,” Glimmer said. “You can’t be fidgety already.”

“That was my settling in breath, thank you,” Adora said back.

“That comes out as less of a huff,” Glimmer said.

“Really?” Adora said. “You’ve cataloged my various breaths?”

“She’s right,” Catra said. “Although your fidgety is more of a two-stage huff. That was just all one.”

Glimmer shrugged as she said, “It can be other.”

Madison was looking between the three as they said, “How long have you known each other?”

“Years,” Catra said with a long-suffering sigh and a smile.

“Almost seven years now,” Adora said. “Glimmer and I lived together for a couple of years in college as well. We’re pretty close.”

Madison nodded but didn’t respond. The conversation died off again as Adora fought the urge to play on her phone. A few minutes before nine, Fran finally stepped out of a door and called Madison’s name. They all got up and went over and Adora noticed that Fran looked like she hadn’t got a wink of sleep. She had a huge mug from a local gas station in her hand and Adora could smell coffee coming out of it.

“Follow me,” she grunted and went down a narrow hall. As they stepped back, Adora felt like everything suddenly got muffled as they passed door after door. It took her a moment to realize the rooms were probably sound baffled to avoid any private conversations filtering into the hall. Fran took a corner and went into the first door on the right. Inside was a small room with a tiny desk with two chairs in front of it and two more crammed against the wall where the door swung.

“Have a seat,” Fran sat as she yawned and sat down. She took a drink off her coffee and stretched a little before looking at the monitor and then back to them. “Alright, thank you for showing up on-time. Now, here’s what’s going to happen today. Catra, Adora, we’re going to run full background checks on you both and try to get you set up to be a temporary place of shelter for Madison if that’s still what you want.” Catra and Adora nodded and Fran went on. “Madison, is that what you want as well?”

“Can… can I ask a question first?” Madison said.

“Sure,” Fran said.

“What about my sisters, ma’am?”

The room went silent, the only noise coming from the little fan on Fran’s computer. Glimmer froze as she was pulling out her own laptop and the rest were staring at Madison.

“I’m sorry,” Fran said. “I didn’t know you had sisters.”

Madison nodded as they went back to chewing on the edge of their coat before realizing they needed to say more.

“Three,” Madison said.

“And you’re worried something might happen to them?” Fran asked.

“Yes, ma’am,” Madison replied.

Fran held a finger up and picked up her phone and dialed a number from memory. A few seconds went by and then she started speaking.

“Hey, Charlie. Yeah, it’s Fran. That EO you’re working on for me? I need you to get it done now and add three more. Hang on,” Fran said. “Madison, what are their names and ages?”

“Ruth, she’s 15, Kayleigh, she’s 14, and Riley, she’s 13,” Madison said as Fran wrote down the names and ages before having Madison spell each one to be sure before checking that the last names were the same.

“You still there, Charlie? Got all of that? Read it back,” Fran said and then was silent for a moment before nodding. “Call me if you hit any roadblocks. Yes, I owe you. Later.”

“What was that?” Madison asked.

“We were already working on an EO, sorry, an emergency order, to keep you safe,” Fran said. “We’re adding your sisters now.”

“What’s that mean?” Madison said.

“That we’re taking this seriously,” Fran said. “For now though, I need to focus on you. I promise we’ll do what we can.”

“Are you going to take them away?” Madison said.

“I don’t know,” Fran said. “What is going to more than likely happen is we go and look at your parent’s home and interview your sisters. Then we’ll make our next decisions. For now, we need to focus on you.”

Madison nodded, going back to chewing on the corner of their coat collar. The next hour or so was taken up with paperwork, questions asked to Madison, and back and forth between Fran and people on the phone. She left the room twice and was gone for a bit. During the second time, Catra asked Madison how they were holding up.

“I’m OK, ma’am,” Madison replied.

Catra shook her head as she said, “Alright, I know why you do it but I gotta say, don’t call me ma’am. Please.”

“I didn’t mean to make you mad,” Madison said in a quiet voice as they seemed to huddle in on themself.

“You didn’t,” Catra said with a smile. “I promise. It’s just not my thing, OK?”

Madison nodded but everyone could see they didn’t quite believe it. Adora knew that feeling. Her mother had been the queen of saying one thing, and being convincing of it, and then lashing out about it later. It’d actually caused a huge problem with her and Catra more than once when Adora hadn’t believed something Catra had said or even done the same thing herself without even thinking about it. She decided now wasn’t the time to address deep psychological wounds though and spoke up.

“Madison, we’re going to have to hit the grocery store for a few things before we get home,” Adora said. “How about thinking of a few things you want, alright?”

“Do you want me to make a list?” Madison said and Adora could hear them doing everything in their power not to say ma’am.

“Yeah, that’s a good idea, thank you,” Adora said and felt bad at how much Madison seemed to suddenly glow at the tiny bit of validation. Glimmer passed them a piece of paper and a pen and Madison started writing as they waited. A few minutes later Fran walked back in and sat down with a sigh. Catra, Adora, and Glimmer were all suddenly on high alert at the look on Fran’s face.

Madison looked up from where they were writing, catching the feel of the room shifting but not sure what was going on.

Fran sat back in her chair as she said, "Catra, Adora, both of your backgrounds came back clean. I filled out a home study report based on what I did last night and my boss has approved it. You're both cleared to keep Madison at your place if everything clears. There's some stuff you have to do, classes and such, but nothing too onerous and we'll get time and place sorted later. I've also got you approved for some emergency SNAP benefits and I'm working on getting Madison on HealthOptimum for medical."

Glimmer leaned forward as she said, "OK, that all sounds good, but you said if everything clears. What's that about?"

Fran frowned as she said, "There's a hitch. Madison, your parents have arrived. We had to notify them of what was going on and did so first thing."

"What about, you know," Catra said.

"The bruises? Yes, I know," Fran said. "It's what's keeping this from being more of a sh… shoot show."

"What does this mean?" Glimmer said as Madison moved back in their chair and seemed to sink into their coat.

“They’ve brought a lawyer of their own,” Fran said. “I just got the EO filed with our judge but they’re already contesting it. They want Madison to return with them. I’m making what maneuvers I can as it is my opinion that Madison should not be in that environment. CASA is sending a representative to speak with Madison and they’ll have their own recommendation.”

“I don’t want to go back,” Madison said from the depths of their coat.

“I know,” Fran said. “Your opinion matters as well but I can’t blatantly ignore the law or a judge.”

Catra muttered something under her breath that Adora caught that consisted of she damn well would. Fran’s eyes flicked towards Catra but didn’t give any other indication she heard.

“Would it help if I spoke with the judge?” Glimmer said.

“You probably will need to,” Fran replied. “I’m just waiting to hear where we’re at right now.” She looked around the room at the four as she sighed. “I warned you that you might hate me before this is all over.”

“I know you’re doing what you can,” Adora said but the words sounded false even to her own ears. Fran took it for the spirit it was given though and just nodded.

“I am,” Fran said, her voice sounding defeated.

Silence fell over the office except for the sound of Glimmer flipping through something on her computer and Fran clicking around on her computer. After a few minutes of that, Catra sat up a little bit more in her chair and spoke up to Madison.

“Hey, Madison, did you finish that list?”

Madison looked at Catra and then took the sheet of paper off the desk and held it out to Catra. Catra took it and read it over.

“There’s some good stuff on here,” Catra said with a little smile. “We’ve got some of it at the house though but that’s alright, you wouldn’t have known. Are you done or do you want to add more?”

Fran was watching Catra intently as she interacted with Madison. Catra, for her part, was focused on Madison and didn’t notice.

“I’m not done,” Madison said and Catra held the paper back out to them.

“Here you go then. Go ahead and finish it up,” Catra said. “We’ll stop by before we go home tonight.”

Adora heard the ever so slight emphasis Catra placed on we and felt her stomach clench. She knew Catra was trying to be reassuring but she was terrified that it wouldn't work out and they'd all fail Madison, that giving them false hope wasn't something helpful. Madison, for their part, reached forward and took the paper from Catra and went back to thinking and writing. Fran sat back in her chair as they did, eyes flicking between Madison and Catra, as she took a long drink from her coffee.

"I'm just going to go and see where we're at," Fran said as she thumped the mug back down on her desk and then left the room.

Fran was gone for almost twenty minutes. Madison finished up the list and handed it back to Catra who looked it over and asked her questions about it. Adora looked at it as well, Madison's handwriting neat and tight on the page, and noticed that most of it was staple stuff with a few treats thrown in at the very end.

"You did a good job on this," Adora said as she folded up the paper and put it in her pocket.

Madison sat in the chair, shuffling a little, before they finally spoke up.

"Can I ask you something?" they said.

"Yeah, always," Adora said.

“Did you two really steal all the horses at Camp Horde for the Lord?” Madison said.

All three of them stared at Madison for a moment before Catra started laughing.

“No, we didn’t steal any of them,” Catra replied. “Is that what they say about us?”

“I heard that the reason they didn’t have any horses anymore was because they got stolen by you and they couldn’t afford to replace them,” Madison said.

Adora was shaking her head as she said, “No, we didn’t steal any of the horses.”

Then she stopped and thought about how Swift Wind had technically stolen himself from the looks of it and they just hadn’t bothered to say anything when he showed up at Camp Bright Moon. She figured she didn’t need to elaborate though.

“What else have they said about us?” Catra said.

“That you two were possessed, the horse thing, that you were trying to trick people into being gay, and that you were tricked by

some evil people from Camp Bright Moon," Madison said.

"Hey!" Glimmer said, looking up from her laptop. "I didn't trick anyone! If anything, I saved your lives when you decided to go swimming in a flooded river."

"Glimmer's family owns that camp," Adora said. "And let's not get into the river thing right now."

Madison looked at Glimmer with something like mystified interest and seemed like they wanted to ask more questions when Fran finally came back in the room.

"Glimmer, we're going to the judge," Fran said. Everyone started to stand up and Fran shook her head. "No, just Glimmer."

Glimmer took a deep breath as she closed her laptop and packed it away. She was dressed in one of the only button up dress shirts that Adora owned and she was wearing the only pair of slacks that Catra had. It wasn't an awful look but Adora knew it definitely wasn't something Glimmer would have picked to stand in front of a judge.

"Let's do this," Glimmer replied before following Fran out of the office.

The next forty minutes were mostly silent. Madison sat in their chair, the corner of their coat collar in their mouth, and just stared off into the distance. Catra and Adora both tried to engage them in conversation but it would limp along for a few minutes before silence would fall again. The office wasn't even big enough to do much besides just sit and wait.

When the door opened, Catra and Adora both stood up. They weren't sure why but they did so anyway. Fran came into the office alone, holding a manila envelope, and threaded her way past Catra and Adora to sit back down at her desk.

She was smiling.

"The judge has granted our EO," Fran replied.

"Oh, thank fucking God," Catra said as she collapsed back into the chair. Madison seemed a bit scandalized at the language and Catra gave an apologetic grin at them. "Sorry about that."

Adora sat back down as well as she said, "So that means…?"

"That means that Madison will stay with you for now," Fran said, her smile sliding a little as Catra sat back up at the mention of for now. "This isn't remotely over."

"What about my sisters, ma'am?" Madison asked.

Fran's smile went away as she sighed.

"The judge allowed them to be included on the EO but modified it a bit. It's not an immediate pick-up order. Someone is going to talk to them," she said. "It is all going to depend on what gets said and what gets found."

"So they might stay there?" Madison said.

"They might stay there, yes," Fran said. While she managed to meet Madison's eyes, Adora could see she desperately wanted to do anything but look at her.

Madison started crying then. There were no dramatics. There was no noise. There were just tears as they looked down. Adora started to stand but Catra beat her to it by just moving over to the chair Glimmer had been sitting in and putting an arm around them. Madison clenched up for a moment before leaning into her.

"You will do everything you can," Catra said, looking at Fran.

"I will," Fran said.

Glimmer came in a minute later, escorted back by someone, and looked at Madison crying on Catra.

“Ah, you heard,” Glimmer said.

“I went ahead and told them,” Fran said. “Anything change?”

“Nope,” Glimmer said. “Just got my copy of the paperwork.”

“Well, we’ve done as much as we can for now,” Fran said as she handed the envelope she’d brought in to Adora. “Here’s a SNAP card for you, details on the medical stuff and what you need to do if they need a doctor immediately, and some general resources. The CASA worker wasn’t able to make it but they’ll be in touch with you as well, probably tomorrow. I will as well.”

Adora took the envelope. She wasn’t sure what to say. She knew she should feel good, Madison wasn’t going back, but the thought of the other three sisters, people she’d never met but she still felt for, was already rattling around in her head.

“Thank you,” Adora said, not feeling very thankful even though she knew Fran was trying.

“Come on, I’ll show you out the back door,” Fran said.

Glimmer called Bow as they walked. Fran led them through an office space filled with cubicles to a back door.

“Madison, good luck,” Fran said.

“Thank you, ma’am,” Madison said as they pulled their coat tight around themself.

Fran opened the door and Adora could see Bow parked at the curb. Everyone headed out, Adora last, and as the door shut behind her, she heard Fran mutter something she could just barely hear.

“I hate this fucking job.”

Adora turned around to say something to Fran but the door was already shut, a large sign declaring it as Not A Public Entrance staring Adora in the face.

Chapter End Notes

> I’ve dealt with CPS people before. Some of them sucked, power tripping bullies and incompetents who should have never been in the position. Some of them though, like Fran, did what they could, as best they could, and it burned through them. It’s a job that has you witness the absolute worst that other people can do to the most vulnerable of our populations and having to deal with it, without having much help, budget, or backing. I felt for people like her. They wanted to make a difference and they got thrown into the fire and then ground up. There’s plenty to criticize in how these kinds of agencies are run but my hat is off to anyone like Fran who is in there fighting the good fight.

To those wondering how Fran was going to be, were they an enemy or an ally, I'd say Fran is neither. She's trying to be an ally but them she isn't, not really. An ally is someone who suffers and risks the same as the person they're allied with. Fran isn't going to suffer like Madison will if they go back to their parents. In the end, it is still just a job and to be the ally that might be needed would cause her to lose it. Fran knows this and it's what eats her up because she knows she won't overstep that line. This isn't a criticism of Fran, it's a nature of reality because not many people would do that. It's why Fran said what she said as she shut the door. She's definitely not an enemy though. She's doing what she can. As I said, thrown into the fire and then ground up.

Anyway, thank you for reading!

Chapter Four

Chapter Summary

Everyone heads back to Bow and Glimmer's house for a little rest.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Bow was upbeat as they drove away from the building.

“Madison, glad to see you’re still with us,” Bow said.

“Thank you,” Madison replied, their voice tired.

Bow shot an inquiring look at Glimmer who was leaned back in the passenger seat.

“It didn’t go quite as planned,” she said. “Yes, Madison will stay with them. However, they have sisters and we don’t know what’s going on with that yet.”

“No,” Bow said softly before meeting Madison’s eyes in the rearview. “I’m so sorry. I hope it goes well.”

“It’s in God’s hands,” Madison said, their face showing just what they thought of God’s hands at that moment.

“Yeah, screw that, it’s in our hands,” Catra said. “Sure, it wasn’t what we wanted but damn, Glimmer has got us this far. Fights not over until it’s over.”

“Sage wisdom, really,” Adora said, nudging Catra with her shoulder.

“We’re not all philosophy students,” Catra said, nudging her back. “You got something to say instead?”

“Yep. I believe it was Socrates who once said, ‘Fight until the fight be-eth done.’ Truly inspiring words,” Adora said.

“Must be better in the original Greek,” Glimmer said.

“It’d have to be,” Catra said.

Adora looked at Madison, who at least had a trace of a smile on their face now, as she said, “Hey, we joke but really, this isn’t done and neither are we.”

“Why are you doing this though?” Madison said.

“People helped us, now it’s our turn,” Catra said.

“Because we can,” Bow said.

“Because we must,” Adora replied.

“Because it’s right,” Glimmer said.

“I change mine to Glimmer’s,” Catra said.

“Of course you would,” Glimmer said to Catra before looking back at Madison. “And before you say it, no, we don’t have to but we’re doing it because we want to.”

Madison settled back in the seat as they wiped at their eyes.

“Thank you.”

“Hey, it’s not a problem,” Adora said. “And speaking of things that are a problem, food. I need some food. I believe I was promised some lunch.”

“Adora, always on point,” Bow said with a laugh. “Where do I need to go? Madison, you got a choice?”

Madison looked between everyone with a slightly panicked face before saying, “Whatever you want.”

“The Porthole it is then,” Catra said.

“We are not taking Madison to the Enclave,” Glimmer said with a roll of her eyes.

“What? There’s nothing wrong with it,” Catra said. “It’s all ages.”

“No, it’s eighteen to enter,” Glimmer said. “Besides, I don’t think they’re even open yet.”

“Oh, yeah, that’s right,” Catra said. “I rescind my suggestion.”

“Where are you talking about?” Madison asked.

“The Porthole is a kind of diner slash club down in the Enclave,” Adora said.

Madison hesitated for a moment before they said, “Um… I’m sorry, ma’am, but what’s the Enclave?”

“Oh, yeah, you probably wouldn’t have heard about that,” Adora said and suddenly felt vaguely uncomfortable, even though she knew there was nothing wrong. She shoved down what she knew was her upbringing and went on. “It’s the main queer district here in the city. Clubs and stores and stuff.”

“It’s where Pride is held every year,” Catra said. “If you want, we’ll take you.”

“Hey, hate to cut this off but I’m just kind of driving,” Bow said. “Where am I going?”

“Go to The Dromedary,” Glimmer said. “We can do pick up and just go back to the house.”

Everyone agreed that sounded good and Bow started towards the restaurant. It wasn’t far from where they were and on the way, Adora could see that Madison looked uncomfortable, more so than they had been. They made their way into a little district sitting in the middle of a neighborhood with a theater announcing its production of Cabaret coming up. A junk shop sat next to that and then dotted here and there along a few blocks were various businesses like a tattoo parlor, hair salon, and restaurants. Wide sidewalks with shade trees and benches ran in front of everything.

Bow pulled up in front of the restaurant, an outline of a camel painted onto the glass door showing where they were. As they got out, Bow waved at someone leaning on the railing on the second floor as they smoked out on the balcony of their apartment. The person gave a little head nod back.

Once inside, Adora looked around, wondering what it looked like to Madison. It was a pretty typical independent restaurant with an exposed ceiling, concrete floor, Edison lights hanging down, and metal chairs at the tables. Adora remembered when she'd first visited a place like this, she'd been amazed at what she thought of as the exotic feel of the whole thing, only having visited chain restaurants and cafeterias with her mother before. Madison didn't really have much of a reaction that Adora could see as they looked at the menu chalked up on the wall.

"Get what you all want," Glimmer said. "I'm paying."

"We can get ourselves," Catra said.

"I know but I'm still paying," Glimmer said.

"No, I'm not having you cover us," Catra said.

"OK, we're going to have our same argument we always have and then I'm still going to do it," Glimmer said.

“We’re going to get you sometime,” Adora said.

Madison stepped up to Glimmer then and tentatively said, “Uh, ma’am, what’s my limit?”

“What do you mean?” Glimmer said.

“What’s my price limit?” Madison said.

Glimmer shrugged as she said, “I don’t know. I guess none. Get what you want.”

Madison looked up at the menu again and then said, “Can I get the vegetarian stuff?”

“It’s alright, get whatever you want,” Bow said. “I’m going to get the portobello sandwich and minestrone myself. What sounds good to you?”

“I guess that,” Madison said. “Is that alright?”

“That’s fine,” Glimmer said with a smile. “Tell the guy at the counter.”

The worker, who'd been standing at the counter watching the interaction, picked up a pen as he said, “Whatcha you want?”

“Are you sure?” Madison said to Glimmer who gave a gesture of go ahead.

Madison tentatively gave their order before backing up, looking at Glimmer, who began her order. Madison backed up some more and ended up standing by the door, hands in their pocket while they looked around. They pulled their phone out and then looked down at it before shaking their head and putting it away.

“Kaitlyn said your phone got turned off,” Adora said as she went to stand by Madison.

“It is,” Madison said. “I was going to play on it at least but it ran out of charge.”

“Sorry,” Adora said. “We’ll plug it up when we get to Bow and Glimmer’s place.”

“Is it alright if I ask you a question?” Madison asked, their voice low.

“Sure, anything,” Adora said.

“You said you go to Pride. I don’t think I want to go,” Madison said before her voice got even lower. “Isn’t it like… an… you know…”

Madison was blushing hard now and Adora was remembering some stuff she’d heard as a kid about how it was a non-stop debauched party of depraved individuals.

“I think I know what you’re asking,” Adora said. “No, it’s not anything bad. It’s a parade and a festival. Yeah, there’s parties at the bars but you’re underage, you can’t go to those anyway. Admittedly, the parade and festival are like something you’ve probably never seen but it really isn’t that bad. It’s not for months either and if you don’t want to go, you don’t have to.”

Madison seemed doubtful but they nodded as they said, “I just, I don’t know anything.”

“You know who you are,” Adora said. “Figured it out faster than I did too. Took me until I was eighteen to admit it.”

Madison shuffled their feet a little as they said, “I didn’t want to.”

Adora realized how the last day had gone for Madison and said, “No, I guess you probably didn’t. I’m sorry all of this is going on. I bet it’s not what you would have picked for it to go.”

Madison shook their head as Bow came up, carrying their food.

"We're ready if you are," Bow said.

Madison stepped over and opened the door for Bow and he went out thanking them for their help. Everyone followed, thanking Madison as they did, and they were soon in the car for the short drive to Glimmer and Bow's home.

It was an old house they'd bought just down the street from the little district. Glimmer and Bow had managed to buy it with a little luck and some first time home buyer grants. It'd been a bit rugged when they'd moved in but Catra had spent weekends helping them fix the place up and now it was a nice little home. The front railing on the porch had been removed and replaced by beautiful wrought iron that Catra had forged as a present for the two. Bow dropped them off at the front before driving into the backyard and parking under a little awning. The inside of the house was painted in bright colors and Adora felt herself relax as she took a deep breath and smelled the floral incense that Glimmer's Aunt Casta had made for her.

"Hey, Madison needs a charger," Adora said.

Glimmer nodded and helped Madison get it hooked up before they all went into the kitchen and settled down. Bow sat down right after and they handed out the food. Catra started to take a bite of her pasta when Madison quietly bowed their head. Everyone froze for a second before Adora and Bow followed along. Glimmer and Catra just quietly waited and after about twenty seconds, Madison

looked back up with a quiet amen and took a bite out of the sandwich.

"Whatta you think?" Bow asked.

"It's good," Madison said.

"Well, while I waited, I got a chat group going," Bow said. "I've got some offers of clothes and hygiene stuff from various people. We just need sizes for the clothes. Lots of offers of help too if we need it."

"Who in the world did you hit up?" Catra said.

"I did not 'hit up' anyone," Bow said with a laugh. "I just told them I was looking for whatever they could offer. Scorpia and Perfuma answered almost immediately. Casta said she's got some good socks and she'll ask around her community. Kaitlyn can't give anything at the moment, Frosta either, but both said to let them know if there's something they can commit time to and Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio said they can do a fundraiser at their next gig if we want. I haven't heard from Spinne or Tossa but they're both at work so I probably will later. Mista and Sea Hawk haven't responded either but they're out of cell range last I heard anyway."

"I still can't believe someone trusted him with a boat," Glimmer snorted as she arranged her salad just so.

“May I ask who they are?” Madison said.

“Yeah,” Bow said. “They’re friends of ours.”

“We’ve known them for a while now,” Catra said and then thought for a moment. “Did you just hit up everyone who was tied to the camp in one way or another?”

“I guess, yeah,” Bow said. “I mean, that’s kind of our core friend group. I was going to talk to some people at work as well.”

“I think we’re good with this for now,” Adora said.

“You didn’t have to do this for me, I know it’s hard to do, but thank you, sir,” Madison said.

“It’s not hard to do,” Bow said. “It’s a blessing I can give to you.”

Madison looked down as they took a bite of their soup with a quick nod and the conversation ended up drifting to various other things. Shows that had been watched, politics, work, and just general little jokes and stories were discussed between the friends. Madison stayed quiet through the meal and when it was all over, started to gather up the trash.

“Nope, you’re a guest,” Bow said as he gently took one of the paper containers from them. “How about you go and relax in the living room, alright?”

“I don’t mind, sir,” Madison said.

“I know but please, let me,” Bow said.

Madison finally sat down the things they’d picked up and went into the living room. They sat down on the couch and spent a moment looking around. There were built-in bookshelves on either side of a fireplace across from the couch and a television in the corner. They sat on the couch, their thoughts whirling as they tried to make some sense of everything that had happened as their head dropped a little. Adora came in a minute later and then quietly went back into the kitchen.

“They’re asleep,” Adora said with a finger to her lips.

“I think we do the same in a few,” Glimmer said. “You want to stay for dinner and we’ll take you back home in the evening?”

Catra shook her head as she said, “Naw. Let’s get an hour or so nap in and then do that grocery shopping. Then we can head home.”

“OK, that sounds like a plan,” Bow replied.

They cleaned up and the four went down for a nap. Catra and Adora lay down in the guest bedroom with the door open. About an hour in, Catra suddenly snapped awake. She sat up and heard Madison moving around and got up out of bed. She walked out into the living room where Madison jumped a little from where they were looking at the books on the shelf.

“I’m sorry, I had to get up and use the restroom, ma’am…, uh, I mean…,” Madison stuttered out.

“It’s alright, it’s alright. You don’t have to apologize, OK?” Catra said, holding her hands up before gesturing at the shelves. “They’ve got quite a library don’t they?”

Madison turned and looked at the books again as Catra came to stand beside them.

“They do,” Madison said as they started to reach out for one and then stopped.

“This one?” Catra said as she took a book down. Madison nodded as Catra handed it to them. They flipped it over and saw two cartoon mice sitting under a swastika with a cat skull on top staring back from the cover.

“What’s it about?” Madison said as they flipped over the back and just saw various blurbs.

Catra remembered reading it when Glimmer had got it and weeping when she did.

“The Holocaust,” Catra replied. “It’s very good but it’s… it’s rough.”

Madison put it back next to the second volume and pulled out another book.

“What’s this about?”

Catra looked at the cover and grinned. It was some manga that Glimmer was in love with but Catra didn’t know much about beyond Glimmer’s rambling about the plot that she knew wouldn’t make sense if she tried to explain it.

“I really don’t know. You’d have to ask Glimmer,” Catra said.

Madison flipped through it for a moment and then put it back. They moved down a little and looked at a few textbooks before pulling out a book that they immediately opened up. Catra caught the author’s name.

“Adora gave that to Bow a while back,” Catra said.

“Oh, I didn’t know I wasn’t supposed to touch it,” Madison said as they started to close it and Catra put her hand in front of the shelf.

“It’s alright. Neither of them will mind,” Catra said. “You picked it because it was C.S. Lewis didn’t you?”

Madison nodded as they said, “I loved the Narnia books. What are The Screwtape Letters?”

Catra knew because Adora had talked in length about it when she’d first discovered it in her sophomore year at college and wondered how Madison was going to react but was spared answering when Adora came into the room.

“Did you ask what The Screwtape Letters are?” Adora said with a yawn.

Madison turned around as they said, “I’m…, yes. She said it was alright to look at it.”

“It’s fine,” Adora said as she came over to them. “It’s a novel about a demon, Wormwood, who’s on his first assignment to Earth and his Uncle Screwtape in Hell writes him about how to

tempt a human. It's an apologetic text and Lewis wrote it to explore themes about Christianity."

Madison's face was multiple shades of emotions as they looked between Adora and the book.

"You mean, it's… demonic?"

"No," Adora said. "Lewis was very much a Christian. I've got a copy at home you can borrow if you want. I'd love to talk with you about it."

Adora could see that Madison was torn. They wanted to read it but they had heard the word demon and immediately felt weird about the whole thing. They finally put it back on the shelf but Adora could see plenty of thought going on.

"I might want to read it. Maybe," Madison said. Adora couldn't tell if they weren't interested and was just trying to be polite or was having some serious internal turmoil that was keeping them from saying yes immediately.

"OK," Adora said. "We don't have quite as impressive a shelf back home but you're welcome to read anything you want on it."

"Anything on this one too, I bet," Catra said. Madison nodded their head and then changed the subject.

“May I call Kaitlyn and let her know I’m alright?” Madison said.

“Sure,” Catra said. “And maybe we need to set some house rules so you’re not floundering around worried you’re doing something wrong. You OK with that?”

Madison nodded as they said, “Yes.”

“Go ahead and call Kaitlyn first,” Adora said.

Madison walked over and picked up their phone, turning it on, before suddenly realizing that it was cut off.

“Oh, I can’t,” Madison said and then looked a little closer at the phone. “It doesn’t look like it charged much either.”

“Wonder why,” Catra replied as she walked over. She noticed that Madison’s phone had a cracked screen and the case was a bit rough. She was pretty sure it hadn’t charged because of the phone but she didn’t want to make Madison feel ashamed so she picked up the charging cord instead. “I told Glimmer to stop buying those cheap ass charging cords. Leave it on for now and plug it back in. Sometimes that helps. You can use my phone.”

Madison nodded as they did it and set the phone back down. Catra pulled her phone out and flipped it open and dialed for them before handing it over.

Catra heard Kaitlyn answer on the first ring and immediately ask, “Are they alright!?”

“Hey, it’s me,” Madison said.

Catra pulled Adora out of the room so Madison would have some privacy on their call. It was only a few minutes though before Madison came and found them in the guest bedroom.

“You didn't have to leave,” they said. “She said she was in class and we’d talk tonight.”

“Just wanted to give you some privacy,” Adora said. “We’ll see if she wants to come over tonight if you want to hang out.”

“Yes, please,” Madison replied.

“You want to talk about those house rules now?” Catra said.

Madison looked nervous all of a sudden and Adora said, “It’s nothing bad but we’re going to be living together. We just need to

get some stuff laid out so we're all on the same page, OK?"

"Yes, ma'am," Madison said.

Adora just smiled as she sat on the edge of the bed. Catra leaned against the wall as she said, "Is there a rule you want?"

Madison looked confused as they said, "What do you mean?"

"Like, is there something that you want to make a rule about. Like no yodeling?" Catra said.

Madison let a little laugh out before they said, "I don't know."

"Think about it," Adora said. "Let's start with this. You're seventeen, you don't need a bedtime. You can put yourself to bed when you're ready but let's say no loud noises past ten pm and no bright lights either. Do you agree to that?"

Adora could see that she'd thrown Madison for a loop again by asking if they agreed but Madison nodded their agreement.

"Don't leave wet towels on the floor and rinse your dishes off," Catra said. "We'll split chores when we get home and can write some up but we'll do our part too."

“O… OK,” Madison said.

“You can have friends over but just let us know and we’ll do the same for you,” Adora said.

“But it’s your house,” Madison said, their voice low and confused.

“Yours too now,” Catra said.

“Listen, yeah, we’re your guardians I guess but you’re almost an adult,” Adora said. “You’ve got a place with us as long as you want and I see no reason why we shouldn’t treat you as an adult. If there’s a problem, we’ll all talk it out.”

“We’re not your betters in other words,” Catra said.

Adora could see that Madison didn’t quite believe it but didn’t push it. They actually raised their hand a little before stopping and saying, “I think I have a rule.”

“Shoot,” Catra said.

“Can I eat vegetarian?” they said and then straightened up a little. “I mean, I want to eat vegetarian.”

Catra almost said that wasn’t really a rule but stopped herself and said, “Sure. Madison eats vegetarian.”

Adora could see that Madison felt a little more grounded having made a statement like that and felt her heart warm. They talked about rules for a few minutes until Glimmer came into the room, her hair a bit frazzled from her nap.

She yawned a little as she said, “Ah, I see everyone else is already up.”

“Bow’s still asleep,” Adora said.

“No, he’s logged in and checking up on his job,” Glimmer said. “His typing woke me up.”

“Well, we’re just laying out some rules for the house,” Adora said. “I think we’ve got the high points. Just be considerate of each other and we’ll address others as they come up.” She held her hand out to Madison and looked them in the eye. “Deal?”

“Deal,” Madison said as they shook her hand.

Catra shook their hand as well and then said, "How about you all go to the grocery store now. I'm going to stay though because I was thinking that I've still got some iron pipe in your shed, Sparkles, and I wanted to see if I had enough to make a little temp screen so Madison has some privacy in the living room."

"Oh, good idea!" Adora replied. "You sure you don't want to come?"

"Yeah, I'm going to try and see if I can put it together with what I have or if we need to hit a hardware store on the way home," Catra said.

"Not that one down the street from you I hope," Glimmer said.

"Hey, I made up with that guy," Catra said.

"I still can't believe you had beef with a damn hardware store clerk," Glimmer said.

"Well, don't call me deary and then be wrong about something as basic as hammers!" Catra said.

"We are not rehashing this," Adora said. "Come on. Let's go get Bow."

The four left the room and told Bow the plans. They grabbed some big reusable grocery bags and headed out the back. Catra gave Adora a kiss goodbye and told Madison she'd see them soon and then headed towards the shed sitting under a big oak tree in the backyard.

"I'll be right there," Glimmer said as she followed Catra.

"I still know the combination," Catra said over her shoulder.

"No, I wanted to talk to you for a minute," Glimmer said as she got up to Catra as she started to open the shed.

"What about?" Catra said as she tried to work the lock and then grunted as she couldn't get it open.

"Thought you still knew the combo?" Glimmer said.

"I do," Catra said as she rattled it a little and finally got the hasp to open. "The damn thing is getting rusty. Cheap ass lock."

"You bought it," Glimmer said and ignored Catra making a flapping hand gesture like a blabbering mouth. "Seriously though, I kind of caught your attitude early today about not going along if the judge decided Madison had to go back. You know what kind of trouble you would have been in?"

Catra stopped, the shed door half-way open, before turning to Glimmer.

"It would have been the right thing," she said quietly.

"It would have landed you in jail," Glimmer said.

"They have to catch me first and then prove it," Catra said.

Glimmer pinched her nose for a moment before she said, "Yeah, I know and you know I'd defend you in court but seriously, think it out."

Catra tapped the edge of the door for a moment before saying, "You know I was in foster care. It was fucking awful. I saw those marks on them, especially that one on their back. Do you know how many times I had bruises like that and CPS did fuck-all for me? Said shit like I was just clumsy or I was doing it to myself for attention. I will not let them go back to that. If the system fails them then fuck it, I won't."

"Well, it's not," Glimmer said.

"Not yet," Catra said. "We'll see."

“I got to know,” Glimmer said, “what would you even do?”

Catra almost didn’t answer but when she did, she kept it vague.

“I’d have been sure they stayed free long enough to make it to their eighteenth birthday and could make their own decisions.”

“Now I gotta know how,” Glimmer said.

Catra frowned but just said, “Could go up to around where your parents live, could go somewhere else. I know people.”

Glimmer was about to laugh and say Catra would stick out like a sore thumb in a rural area when she suddenly remembered that Catra had lived for several years working as a traveling farrier all through that area as well as other rural areas. She wouldn’t have a problem blending in and probably did know plenty of people who’d have taken her and Madison in for long enough to do what she had stated. Only Adora would be able to talk her out of it if it came to that and Glimmer wasn’t a hundred percent sure that Adora would.

“OK, but you don’t have to,” Glimmer said. “I think we’re on a good track.”

Catra gave her a smile that Glimmer didn't like at all as she said, "Let's just hope it stays that way. Now go on, Bow is giving me the stink eye for keeping you."

Glimmer didn't say any more and turned away as Catra waved at the car before getting the door of the shed the rest of the way open. She immediately caught a rake that fell out towards her and knew Glimmer had probably put away the garden stuff at the end of summer. She pulled out the rake, a weedeater, a weeding sickle, a hoe, and the lawnmower before she was finally able to get into the small shed. Sitting on a stand in the back was an old gas forge that Catra had built a few years before and finally stored at Glimmer's house when she'd made enough money to get a larger one. Next to it was an old toolbox she'd left over there when she'd got a new one from Adora for their anniversary. She pulled the toolbox outside and opened it up and looked at the mix of store bought and hand-made smithing tools inside.

Catra grinned as she picked up a straight-peen hammer. She'd made it herself and she remembered how happy she'd been as it'd been an improvement over other tools she'd made at the time. Now, with more experience, she could see all the little problems it had but it was still a good solid hammer and she thought she should maybe bring it home and throw it in with her current set. After a few more minutes rummaging around in the toolbox, she went back inside and found the iron pipes. She was happy to see they were all cut to six feet and were sitting in a bucket so they hadn't rusted since the floor occasionally flooded. She found a box full of fittings and hauled them and the pipe outside. She was laying the pipe out on the ground when she heard someone in the backyard.

"Why isn't anyone answering the door?"

Catra looked up from where she was kneeling on the ground going through the fittings to see a man standing in a tidy suit, his black hair carefully arranged. Catra was confused for a moment, wondering if maybe it was some CPS worker, when she saw the shorter woman standing behind him, dressed in a plain denim skirt with her long hair braided back. Catra immediately recognized Madison's features on the woman.

"Because no one is here," Catra said as she got to her feet.

"Oh, good, I was worried you didn't understand me," the man said. "Listen, where are the residents of this house?"

"Who are you?" Catra said, crossing her arms.

The man looked irritated as he said, "My name is Liam Keel. I'm trying to find the residents of this house."

"You supposed to be here?" Catra said.

"Don't give me your lip," Liam said as he moved his suit coat a little. Catra couldn't help but notice the belt around his waist and felt herself go coldly furious when she saw it was the width of the mark across Madison's back.

“Fuck you,” Catra said. “Get the fuck out of here right now.”

Catra noticed that Madison’s mother looked appalled at her language as Liam said, “Don’t speak like that in front of my wife.”

“I don’t think I stuttered. It’s time to leave, buddy,” Catra said.

“No. I am here to get my daughter,” Liam said. “I have a pretty good idea of who you are then. You’re not going to corrupt my daughter.”

“I believe I said fuck you,” Catra said and then waved her hand like she was shooing a fly. “Now get.”

Liam started to step forward and his wife touched his arm.

“Maybe we should go,” she said.

“Shut up, Caroline,” Liam said as he shook her hand off and advanced on Catra. “What are you going to do? Call the police?”

Catra shrugged as he stopped just out of reach.

“You are not going to hurt them anymore and I’m not some helpless kid,” she said. “Leave, now.”

“Or what?” he said with a sneer.

Catra spoke matter of factly, her voice never going above a conversational tone, as she looked him right in the eyes.

“You’re going to leave them alone. Don’t come around again because Glimmer might sue you, Bow will try and talk it out, and my wife will try to appeal to your better nature before doing anything else but me, I’ll kill you if I see you again. I’ll bury a hammer between your eyes and spit on your face as the light fades from your eyes.”

Liam’s eyes went wide as he tried to say something, stopped, and then finally spoke.

“You think you can threaten me!?” Liam said. “I’ll call the police!”

“Good, you recognize it’s a threat,” Catra said. “Do whatever you want except don’t come around again. I won’t warn you again.”

Liam stepped up to her, looming over her, as he said, “You know I’ll get her if I want.”

Catra grinned back at him, all teeth, as she said, “I sincerely hope you try.”

“Liam!” Caroline said.

Liam didn’t turn around but he finally just gave a fake smile as he backed up and said, “Better watch out.”

Catra held her tongue as he started to head for the driveway but then she heard him say something about his other daughters and didn’t even try to stop the next words out of her mouth.

“I’ll make sure the rest get away from you too.”

Liam turned around, his face furious, and started for her. Catra calmly reached down and picked up the straight-peen hammer.

“Sure you want to dance with an adult for once, shitbag?”

Liam took a few more faltering steps before stopping again. Catra just stood and waited to see what he was going to do. Finally, after what felt like five minutes but was more like just a handful of seconds, he turned his back and stomped off without another word.

A minute later, Catra heard a car door slam and tires squealing on the pavement out front. She sagged forward, dropping the hammer on the ground, as she put her hands on her knees and took a deep, shuddering breath. She was still jittery forty-five minutes later when the rest came back.

Catra plastered a smile across her face as Bow popped the hatchback and took out a few bags. Catra's smile became genuine when she saw Madison with a little smile on her face while she told Glimmer about something. Adora came over to her for a hug and whispered in her ear.

"What happened?"

"What makes you think anything happened?" Catra whispered back.

Adora pulled back with a raised eyebrow as she said, "Because I'm your wife."

"Well, wife, don't worry about it for now. Let's get on home. Promise we'll talk about it later," Catra said and then nodded at Madison. "They're happy."

"They really loved grocery shopping, I think," Adora said. "They opened up pretty quick, talking about all these dishes they know how to cook and how they wanted to change them to veggie dishes. We have so much tofu now."

Catra laughed but she still tucked the hammer into her belt as she helped get everything situated and ready to leave.

Chapter End Notes

If you're wondering what the graphic novel was about the Holocaust, it's Maus. I don't know why I didn't name it, I just didn't. The manga wasn't anything in particular though.

Now, normally, I change the names of things for this AU. In one story, Bow and Adora have a little moment between them about Fruit Fables, my re-name of Veggie Tales. So why didn't I do it for C.S. Lewis? I don't know. It just seemed right. Learned a bit more about Lewis when I wrote this too. Did not know he became an atheist at one point and then came back to Christianity. I also did not know that The Screwtape Letters was dedicated to Tolkien either.

I said before that Camp Bright Moon and Camp Horde for the Lord are both based on places I know and although they aren't exact one-to-one recreations, I could still take you to them and say, "This is this place, this is that place."

The places in this story, particularly this chapter, are the same. I've just changed the names in some cases. One of them sadly doesn't exist any more, in fact the camp that Camp Bright Moon is based on doesn't either now that I think of it, but that's how these things go. At least I get to make little written memories of them.

Anyway, thank you for reading!

Chapter Five

Chapter Summary

It's time for things to move along, decisions to be made, hearts to be broken, and hearts to be mended. It's time for kudzu to grow.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

When all was said and done, Catra pulled Glimmer to the side before they left that afternoon and told her what had happened. Glimmer told her she'd get it taken care of. Madison didn't find out about her father showing up and they went home that night and started getting settled. Catra put up the screen for Madison, a small little area around the couch. They had to move some furniture around but after an hour Catra had hung a few sheets over it, promising to get something better as soon as possible, and Madison had their own private place that only they were allowed access to and could bar anyone with but a word.

The following weeks were a constant stream of communications with CPS as various people wanted information and input on the situation. CASA finally contacted Catra and Adora and interviewed Madison. The final recommendation was that they were in a better place and that they be allowed to stay and Catra and Adora started the classes they needed to take.

Glimmer hadn't been able to get any kind of official sanction against Liam but he'd received a stern warning from Fran, which Catra considered to be about as good as spitting into the wind

and said as much. Fran had just sighed and agreed. For weeks after, Catra kept her eyes open for him, wondering if he'd try it again, but she was surprised that he never did come back around.

They ended up having a little bit of a hassle with the apartments over Madison staying and the fact the police had been pounding on their door in the middle of the night but they managed to get it smoothed over. Having Glimmer show up in full lawyer suit with her business cards when they went to talk with the manager definitely helped out.

The next couple of months were not easy. Madison found out pretty quickly that their homeschooling was grossly deficient. They got them enrolled in GED classes at the college where Adora worked. Fran got Madison into some therapy as well and those days could be hard as Madison would, in the beginning especially, come home with jagged emotions and would lash out without warning. Adora had a harder time handling those moments then Catra did but they both did their best and slowly Madison moved down the road. That's how Adora liked to think of it. She didn't say it was towards recovery because she knew damn well that recovery was not something one reached but something one refined.

Adora found herself going back to church as well when Madison asked about two weeks in to go. She found a place in their town that she thought would serve and she and Madison would get up early on Sundays and go. Catra politely turned down Madison the few times they asked and would have lunch ready for them both when they got back. It didn't last more than a few weeks though. Adora could see Madison was going because they thought they should but it wasn't doing anything for them. Madison sat down

with her Saturday night and they and Adora had a long talk about it after which they chose not to go.

A typical day though was just getting up, getting ready, doing the day's work, and then hanging out in the evening. Madison would sit down in front of a laptop and devour shows they had heard about but hadn't been allowed to watch, read books, or play games. Glimmer helped them dye their hair for the first time, their black hair getting bright strands of blue, green, and purple shot through it. Catra and Adora helped them get a bank account set up and deposited a portion of the money they were receiving from the state for being foster parents into it for them to use. Catra made sure she showed Madison exactly how the rest was being spent because she well remembered having foster parents who only saw her as a paycheck and she didn't want Madison to feel the same. Madison particularly bonded with Bow and the two could spend hours laughing and talking about nothing at all. They were blossoming and Catra commented that watching Madison blossom was like watching kudzu blossom, rapidly and all over the place.

Then one day, they saw the full bloom.

It was mid-spring and the weather was warm and humid with a stiff wind driving small clouds that were gathering in the west and promising thunderstorms that evening. They got out of Catra's pickup, Adora grabbing a bag out of the back, and stood on the edge of a parking lot of a park as they looked out across the grass towards the pond at the bottom of the hill and the little stone footbridge that went over it near the middle. Ducks swam around and waddled across a small island in the middle.

Madison stepped to the edge of the parking lot, their braided hair moving a bit in the wind. They were wearing their favorite clothes, jeans, a Pokemon shirt they'd bought at a local game store that they had found with a bulky bright colored flannel over it, and chunky boots. Pinned to the flannel's collar was a Trans Pride flag pin that they'd gone back and forth on wearing but had finally put on right before they'd got out of the car.

It all happened fast. One moment, Madison was looking around and the next they were flying across the field, shouting at a group of people walking towards the footbridge from the other side. Three of the five shouted back and started running towards the bridge as well.

"I think that's them," Adora said as she waved.

"You think?" Catra said with a smirk as they followed.

Madison collided with their sisters at the footbridge, laughter and tears mixing as they smooshed together in a tight hug that showed no signs of ever ending. They all started talking at once and none of them seemed able to understand a word the other three were saying but it didn't matter. The words flowed together into one thing, love, and that they all understood.

"You must be the Manzanas," a woman said as she stood at the top of the foot bridge with a smile. Catra and Adora went around the siblings reuniting and walked up to meet the sister's foster parents.

“We are and you must be the Dohnals,” Adora said, holding a hand out to shake. “I’m Adora. This is my wife, Catra.”

“I’m Holly,” the woman said and nodded to her husband. “This is Chuck.”

Adora thought they looked like nice people, all smiles and dressed in casual clothes that Adora knew her mother would have called hippy but Adora just thought of as comfortable.

“Nice to meet you both,” Adora said.

“You have any problems?” Catra said as she leaned against the stone work.

“No, they’re delightful kids,” Chuck said. “I mean, they have issues, of course, but no, I think they’re great. We’re looking forward to having them with us.”

Catra looked hard at both of them. She knew how people could put on a happy front and still be hiding something vile behind it and she was doing her best to sniff it out if it was there.

“I mean with the kid’s parents,” Catra said.

“Oh, no, not at all,” Holly replied. “It’s not the first time we’ve been foster parents and it's not like they know where we live.”

Catra just nodded as she had figured out pretty quickly before that Liam had probably used Madison’s phone to track them down to their apartment and then to Glimmer’s house. She figured that when CPS had taken the sisters out of the home a week before that there probably hadn’t been any electronic devices that had gone along that he could have used to follow them. Still, she knew to be cautious.

“Madison doesn’t know this,” Catra said quietly, “but their dad showed up the first day we had them. Luckily I was the only one around. Just a word for you to be cautious.”

Chuck nodded as he said, “Will do. I’ll let our neighbors know to look out as well.”

“Well, I see that you have your picnic too,” Holly said as she pointed at the bag in Adora’s hand as she raised an actual picnic basket up. “You want to sit at that picnic table over there and we can get set up while they get reacquainted?”

They agreed and went and sat at a picnic table under a tall cypress tree. The four chatted about inconsequential things and Adora smiled as she saw Madison and her sisters sitting on the grass by the bridge talking.

After about ten minutes, Catra said, “Adora, I think we might need some more chairs. Could you grab the folding chairs out of the back of the truck?”

Adora agreed and went off towards the truck. Catra watched her go and when she was out of earshot turned to Chuck and Holly.

“Alright, I got to say this,” Catra said. “I think you both seem like decent people but I grew up in foster care.”

“And you think we might be putting on a show,” Holly said.

“Yes, exactly,” Catra said. “I take the term guardian seriously. Madison has gone through enough. I know their sisters have as well. I expect you to step up for them all. I’m keeping my eye on you.”

Chuck nodded as Holly said, “I know the kind of foster parent you’re thinking of and that’s not us. We just want those kids to flourish, same as you.”

Catra leaned on the table as she said, “Alright. I’m not trying to be an asshole but… well, I think you get it.”

“We do,” Chuck said. “We kind of wondered the same about you two, since we’re being honest.”

Catra sat up a little, about to snap back at him that she would never be like that, when she realized they didn’t know her either and it was an honest thing to wonder about.

“OK,” Catra said as she laughed a little, the tension fading out of her. “That’s fair. How about we just agree that we’re both staring at the other all side-eyed and go on from there.”

Chuck and Holly both laughed as well as Holly said, “I think we can do that.”

Riley, Madison’s youngest sister, came running up to Holly and said, “Ma’am, can we go to the other side of the pond, please?”

“Of course,” Holly said as Adora came back with the chairs. “We’re going to eat soon. We’ll let you know when we’re ready.”

Riley went running back, screaming, “She said yes!”

Catra smiled as she watched Madison with their sisters as they walked over the bridge. Adora sat down next to her and looked to where her wife’s eyes were and smiled as well. She’d thought she’d seen Madison happy but she’d never seen them like this.

The rest of the day was relaxing. They had a good lunch and the siblings spent a lot of time talking and running around the park. When it was time to go there were promises of visits and tears when they finally parted. Madison was silent on the ride back home and didn't say much until right before bed.

"Do you think I could get my own apartment?" Madison asked.

"I mean, in the future, yeah, sure, when you're ready," Adora said. "Why, what brings this on?"

Madison didn't seem like they wanted to answer but finally said, "Because I want to be able to take care of my sisters and I know they won't let me if I don't have a place of my own."

Catra sat down on the floor in front of Madison as she said, "It's more than just an apartment you know."

"I know. I'd have to get a job," Madison said. "I'll do whatever I have to do. I know I can't right now but I'm eighteen in just over a month and I've got some of the money you've been giving me saved."

"I think it'd be hard to get a job that'd allow you to do all of that," Adora said. "I get why you want to but that could really mess up your future."

Madison sat back, their face stubborn, as they said, “I don’t care. I’ll work several jobs. That’s my future.”

Catra replied, “How about we write it out. Make a budget, figure out what kind of jobs you could get, and stuff like that.”

Madison perked up and immediately pulled out a pad of paper from their backpack.

“And I guess you want to do this right now,” Catra said with a grin.

It took about two hours as Catra and Adora sat around the kitchen table with Madison to get it all laid out. At the end, Madison was almost in tears as they looked at how the numbers just weren’t lining up, no matter how they juggled it.

“But what if I move to like, Lordon?” they said, referring to a small town near where they lived. “The rent is probably cheaper there, right?”

Adora said, “It is, that’s true, but then you have to spend more on fuel and vehicle maintenance or find jobs there.”

“And I can tell you that the jobs in Lordon are not what they are here,” Catra said.

Madison sat back as Adora passed them a napkin. They blew their nose and wiped their eyes on their sleeve as they said, “It’s impossible then.”

“It’s not impossible but yeah, it’s really unlikely,” Catra said. “I know you want to be with your sisters. We’re going to be meeting with Chuck and Holly frequently so you can do that. You can call them and they can call you. You’ll all be in each other’s lives.”

Madison sighed as they nodded. Adora and Catra slid over and hugged them.

“I’m sorry,” Adora said. “I know how much you wanted this.”

Madison looked around the apartment, fiddling with the napkin in their hand, and Adora could see the old fear, the fear of what an adult might say or do, cross their face as they turned back to them both. She had a pretty good idea what Madison was going to say when they started to speak and she was right.

“I, um, I really appreciate everything you’ve both done…,” Madison said and Adora put a hand on their hand to stop them.

“But you want to go and live with Chuck and Holly don’t you?” Adora said.

Madison started crying again and couldn’t speak but they nodded.

Both Catra and Adora were crying as well as Adora said, “That’s not impossible. If that’s what you want, we’ll talk with Fran about it tomorrow and then approach Chuck and Holly to see if they can do that.”

“I’m sorry,” Madison said, wiping at their eyes.

“Don’t be sorry,” Catra said as she squeezed their shoulder. “I really get it. I’m glad we could get you this far.”

“And you always, and I mean always, have a place with us,” Adora said. “No matter what.”

“Thank you,” Madison said.

It took a little paperwork and such but Chuck and Holly had the room and were more than happy to let Madison stay with them. Catra and Adora helped them get packed and loaded on the final day that Madison was with them and, even though they weren’t supposed to know where they were going to be moving to, drove

Madison to their new home. Chuck had given them the address and had basically said that rule be damned in this case.

The neighborhood was out on the edge of town by a large lake and state park and consisted of large acreages with sprawling ranch style homes. They were going to help Madison unload but their sisters were right there as they pulled up and the three immediately started getting their stuff out of the truck bed. They took a tour of the home, saw the room that Madison would be staying in with their sister Ruth, talked a little bit, and then it was time to go.

"We're going to miss you," Adora said as she hugged Madison tight.

"Yeah, keep in touch, alright?" Catra said.

"I will, I promise," Madison said.

On the drive out, the two of them were both quiet. Suddenly, Catra swerved over to the side of the road and when she came to a stop, put her head against the steering wheel and wept. Adora immediately started weeping as well and pulled Catra to her.

"It's the right thing," Adora said.

"I know," Catra said. "Fuck, I know. I still hate it."

“Me too,” Adora said.

The next few days were rough as they stumbled over the absence of Madison in their lives. More than once one or the other would set a place at the table for Madison and then stand there staring at it before sighing and putting the dish back. Catra didn’t take down the pipe screen for a few days but did so late one evening while muttering under her breath and shaking her head. True to their word though, Madison did keep in contact, and Catra and Adora ended up going out to Holly and Chuck’s place for dinners along with Glimmer and Bow once Holly and Chuck had a chance to meet them.

Madison’s eighteenth birthday came and the party was fantastic. They’d just finished their GED and were planning to go to technical school. Holly and Chuck had been more than willing to let them stay and both Catra and Adora felt a worry they didn’t even know they had leave. Madison had made friends, both at the game shop and at their classes, and they all came to the party. Seeing them so happy, when just months before they almost never cracked a smile, had Catra and Adora both grinning for days after.

Then another month passed and Catra and Adora got to take Madison and their sisters to their first Pride.

They parked at a grocery store just up the street from the main part of the Enclave and spent a moment getting sunblock on everyone. Adora had hoped it’d be at least cloudy but it was a beautiful summer day in June which meant not a cloud in the sky,

very little wind, and the Sun was doing its best to roast everyone alive.

"At least it's not humid," Bow said as he put on sunglasses and a big floppy hat.

"Bite your tongue," Glimmer said, already fanning herself as her sundress moved a bit in a hot breath of air before going still again. "Easy for you in a midriff and shorts."

"But you love it," Bow said in a sing-song voice.

"I do," Glimmer said with a smile as she waved at someone she knew going past.

Madison was standing close to Bow, tugging a little at the binder they'd started wearing the week before, as they looked around.

"You're not wearing that all the time are you?" Bow said.

"No," Madison said. "Today will be the longest I've worn it."

"If it gets uncomfortable, let someone know," Bow said.

“I will,” Madison replied.

Catra couldn’t help but notice that Chuck and Holly looked a bit out of place, looking around at the crowd of people. She knew they’d never come to something like this before and wondered what it looked like to them. There were all kinds of people out. People in leather harnesses walked next to families carrying little kids and the most flamboyant drag performers weaved through the crowds next to the frumpiest dressed person and all over were brightly colored flags held high to announce to the world that here someone was, here is who they were, and by God, they would not be quiet about it.

“Quite the crowd, isn’t it?” Catra said as she slipped up beside Chuck and Holly.

“Uh, yeah,” Chuck said, jumping a little and then laughing at himself.

Holly was smiling as she looked around at the various people and said, “It looks… different.”

“Nah,” Catra said. “This is normal around here.”

Holly turned, her face suddenly falling as she started to stammer out something about how she wasn’t trying to offend and Catra laughed as she put a hand on her shoulder.

“Holly, it’s alright,” Catra said. “I get it. You’re fine. Just have fun.”

“Let’s go get some seats before it gets too crowded by the marshal’s stand,” Adora said as she stepped over to Catra.

“Oh, wait!” Holly said and slid open the side door to their minivan. “Kids, you want your flags?”

Madison and their sisters suddenly perked up and scurried over. Holly pulled out some small flags and handed one to each sibling. Madison’s was a Trans Pride flag and Kayleigh and Riley both had the rainbow Pride flag but Ruth unfurled a Bi Pride flag, looking around a bit nervously as she did but still held it up for everyone to see. Her eyes though, those Adora knew because it was the same look she’d seen in Madison’s eyes months before standing in a hallway and telling a group of cops what their pronouns were.

They all gathered together and Bow pointed about a block or so away and said, “See those bleachers?” Everyone said they did and Bow looked at the siblings. “How about you lead off and find us a place to sit right next to that big raised platform?”

They agreed and the siblings put Riley in front and she took off with a little marching step and a smile. When they finally got seated up on the back of the bleachers, someone started playing music from the parade marshal’s stand next to them. Some kids started dancing in the blocked off road and without even thinking, Madison grabbed Kayleigh’s hand and went down, the other two

sisters following and it was only a moment before the four were dancing and laughing in the middle of the road.

Catra and Adora held hands and looked at the four siblings, happy, healthy, and thriving, and knew it was good.

Chapter End Notes

I say this a lot but I did not expect this to go as long as this did. This isn't much shorter than the story that started this series. This was original a little idea I had and it was supposed to be Madison getting away from an abusive home but they were going to be eighteen. It would have been more of them living with Catra and Adora and just kind of them taking care of this person and paying forward the help they had once received. I figured, five, maybe seven thousand words at most. Then I thought, "No, Madison needs to be seventeen."

That turned everything around. In fact, what I consider to be the biggest points in this fic came about at a last moment. Madison having sisters, Madison being seventeen, and Madison deciding that they didn't want to live with Catra and Adora anymore. All of these these things needed their moment and thus, here we are and I have to say, all of the work in this series is personal in one way or another but writing this one felt the closest to how I felt writing Camp Horde for the Lord.

Credit to the songs that helped this along. I write with a song on repeat a lot of times and this was no different. The part from the beginning to about when Fran shows up was written to After the Eulogy by Boysetsfire on repeat. Then later, it was Remembrance by Balmorhea during the part with Fran. Then during the final chapter, it was Stairway to Heaven by Dolly Parton (a particularly fantastic version of that song). Music really does drive the writing sometimes. Particularly

with After the Eulogy. Having someone chanting, “Where’s your anger/where’s your fucking rage” over and over in your ears while typing Glimmer having to stand up to the police is a great way to set the mood.

I’ll also say that I really have ignored Illusions while I wrote this one. I think I was getting a bit stretched out on that one and needed a break. This had been rattling around in my head a little so I figured this would work out. Now that it’s out, I feel like I can go back to Illusions and start working on getting that done. I do have a way through it and I think I’m getting close to an ending.

As I've said before, I write for myself but I share my work for everyone and I hope that you all did enjoy it.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!